

Prologue

1. Unconcerned Hobbits

The Shire, as one might imagine, had changed little since the beginning of the Fourth Age. Its green hills rolled quietly beneath the sun, its hedgerows stood firm, and its rivers and streams murmured along the familiar courses, as they had for generations. Here and there, a new fence might rise, or a bridge might be mended, but such things were small, and Hobbits are careful folk who regard change with mild suspicion. Indeed, the passing of years had brought little that could disturb the steady rhythms of their lives, and they were content to live them.

It may surprise some, perhaps, that the name of Aragorn the Great, son of Arathorn, once called Strider was still known even in the Shire. A few older Hobbits recalled stories from wandering relatives or from traders who had passed through the Westfarthing, tales of the great deeds that had ended the wars of long ago. Yet, as is often the case with tales of kings and battles, the name had begun to fade from common memory. The Wars of the Ring — the matters of Elves and Men, of Orcs and Ringbearers — were mostly the concern of those far beyond the hills, and the Hobbits, whose lives were measured by harvest, by supper, by the quiet enjoyment of the sun on a green lawn, had little need to dwell upon them.

Still, it was not wholly unknown. Occasionally, a Hobbit might mention Aragorn the Great in passing, speaking of him with a certain polite wonder: “I have heard my grandfather say he saw the King of Gondor once, long ago, when he passed through the northern lands.” Or, “There are tales that speak of the deeds of one who wore the crown after Sauron fell, and how he healed the realms of Men.” Such whispers were usually met with nods and gentle smiles. For the Shire-folk were not unkind, but they were Hobbits, and their hearts preferred the tangible, the small, and the certain over the grand deeds of distant kings.

The fields remained neatly ploughed; the hayricks stood tall and fragrant; the gardens bore cabbages, potatoes, and onions in rows as straight as any Hobbit could desire. Smoke rose from chimneys, curling lazily toward the morning sky. Chickens wandered freely across paths, and the occasional dog trotted happily after them, ears twitching and tongue lolling. Market-days continued in their familiar rhythm, though few traders came from the East or South, and the tales they brought were often embellished, strange, and easily set aside by the prudent Shire-folk.

Hobbits, by their nature, live unconcerned. They do not hurry unnecessarily; they take tea in the afternoon and supper at the appointed time. They measure time by the turning of the seasons and the ripening of fruit. Even the great happenings of Middle-earth, the final defeat of the Dark Lord, the rise of Aragorn, the coming of the Fourth Age, touched them only lightly, like a breeze through the hedges, rather than a storm.

And so the Shire endured, as it had through centuries past. It was a place of quiet, of soft laughter in the evenings, of children running through the green lanes, and of Hobbits content to live in peace, unconcerned with matters that might occupy the hearts of men and elves elsewhere. To those who dwelt within its bounds, the world beyond was vast and mysterious, yet mostly distant. And in that distance lay both safety and the unknown, waiting quietly beyond the hills.

Though the Shire had changed little in appearance, it was not wholly untouched by the passage of time. Some families had moved from one village to another, seeking a bit more land, a gentler

slope, or simply a change of air. A branch of the Proudfoot line had settled near the banks of the Brandywine, where they tended orchards and meadows with careful diligence, while another had moved from Hobbiton to Bywater, taking up a long-neglected cottage with a stout chimney and a walled garden. Such shifts were rarely spoken of beyond the immediate neighbours, for Hobbits do not delight in gossip, yet every move left a subtle trace: a new gatepost, a path freshly trodden, a hedgerow pruned in unfamiliar angles.

Children grew taller in the years between the passing of the Third and Fourth Ages, their laughter echoing differently across familiar lanes. Old hobbit-holes, once occupied by generations long gone, now bore new residents, some of whom took to the rooms with the careful attentiveness of a gardener tending rare plants. And though the roads themselves had not been widened or straightened, the coming and going of carts, the occasional call of a trader, and the movement of milk and cheese between villages reminded all that life, though slow, was never wholly stagnant.

Even the markets had shifted slightly. Small tables and stalls appeared in places where none had been before, offering herbs, linens, and preserves in neat displays, and the merchants themselves, while rarely travelling far from their familiar circuits, spoke in quieter tones of distant lands. Yet the changes were minor, and the Shire-folk adjusted with little fuss. A hobbit who had lived a long life in Hobbiton could still recognize the same winding lanes, the same round doors painted in cheerful colours, and the same hills rolling away toward the horizon. Life, as ever, measured itself by the turning of seasons, the ripening of fruit, and the quiet passage of days, rather than by deeds of kings or wars of men.

Yet these small changes, though subtle, reminded those who paused to notice that the Shire was not frozen in time. Its folks, though cautious and rooted, moved in quiet ways: a family to a new cottage, a garden replanted, a path extended. And in these small movements, the beat of the Shire continued — steady, careful, and aware, if only in the tiniest of ways, that the world beyond its borders went on, and that one day, perhaps, the quiet hills and hedged lanes might feel the touch of the wider world once more.

Through all the changes of the years, through generations and the slow passage of time since the writing of the Red Book, these meals remained unchanged.

In the Shire, as in ages past, the passage of a day was measured not only by light and shadow but by the steady rhythm of meals, for Hobbits are a people of appetites both keen and punctual. Each day began with breakfast, the first meal taken at a leisurely hour, often of bread, butter, and cheese, with tea, or for those with inclination, a small mug of ale. Soon followed second breakfast, mid-morning fare that surprised many outsiders with its generous portions: fried eggs, bacon, sausages, or a slice of cold meat, accompanied by fresh rolls or cakes.

Before the sun had climbed high, there came elevenses, a late-morning snack of small pies, fruit, or sweetmeats, taken often with tea, and much enjoyed by young and old alike. At midday, Hobbits gathered for luncheon, a more substantial repast of cold meats, bread, pickles, and cheeses, sometimes finished with a tart or a slice of pastry. Then, as the sun began its gentle descent toward afternoon, came afternoon tea, a meal of cakes, scones, and light fare, usually enjoyed in garden or parlour, accompanied by quiet conversation or the hum of daily labour.

Evening brought dinner, the main meal of the day, taken at family tables, with plates piled high with stews, roasted meats, root vegetables, and bread fresh from the oven. Ale or cider accompanied this feast, brewed in the yards of the Shire-folk with care and tradition. And yet, even after such a

dinner, Hobbits were not done: a small, lighter meal of supper awaited, perhaps a simple bowl of broth, a bit of cold meat, or a few biscuits, enjoyed in the warmth of the fire before retiring for the night.

Market days in the Shire were occasions of quiet bustle and careful delight. The tables and stalls were set with precision in village greens or along the edges of winding lanes, each item arranged with the attention of a gardener tending his flowers. Here could be found the usual wares of a Shire market: fresh bread, cheeses, cured meats, honey, butter, and jars of preserves, alongside vegetables and fruits in neat heaps, fragrant with the scents of field and orchard. Hobbits moved among them with the gentle efficiency that suited their nature, trading coins and tokens with soft-spoken words and friendly nods.

Yet not all that was offered was ordinary fare. Occasionally, among the humble goods, one might find a trinket of far greater interest: a silver thimble, a carved pipe, a small chest of polished wood — treasures passed down or gathered from some long-remembered adventure. Most notable among such items were those connected, however distantly, to Bilbo Baggins, whose estate had long since passed to the Sackville-Bagginses. Even generations after his journey to the Lonely Mountain, bits of his hoard found their way into market tables: a coin with curious markings, a small brooch, or a book with the smell of far lands. Hobbits purchased these with a mix of practical need and quiet fascination, for a trifle from Bilbo's past carried with it a story, and stories, as every Hobbit knew, were often as satisfying as cheese or bread.

Coins themselves were handled with care. Silver and copper passed from hand to hand in measured clinks, exchanged according to the value known to all who lived within the Shire. Every Hobbits' purse was carefully counted, not for greed, but for comfort, for the assurance that the week's bread and butter could be secured, and perhaps a treat added to the table. There was an order and a rhythm to this trading, and every market day was as much a matter of social gathering as of commerce. Friends and neighbours met, spoke of the weather, of the crops, of the new growth along a favourite hedgerow, and occasionally, if a traveller or distant cousin happened by, tales from lands beyond the hills.

Thus the Shire endured in its measured life: quiet, attentive, and richly detailed, with each market day a gentle reminder that even the smallest folk might treasure not only their daily bread, but also the faint echoes of adventure and history, whether in a coin from far-off lands, or a remnant of the hoard of Bilbo Baggins, whose journeys had touched even the quiet hills of Hobbiton. In this way, the Shire held fast to its rhythms, nourished by routine, by care, and by the small excitements that wrought each day worth the living.

If a stranger were to wander into the Shire in those days — which was seldom done, for strangers were few and far between — they would soon notice the steady creak and rattle of little carts upon the lanes. These were no grand wagons laden with treasure, nor swift carriages such as the Big Folk favour; rather, they were squat, sturdy affairs of oak and ash, varnished against the damp, with wheels cut by hand in the villages of Needlehole and Stock. A well-kept cart could last a family for three generations, and often did.

By the year 1500 by Shire Reckoning, when the memory of Bilbo Baggins had passed into fireside tale, these carts were as much a part of daily life as breakfast itself — and breakfast, as every reader of hobbitish matters knows, is not a thing trifled with.

The carts were drawn by small ponies (or by large cousins when the ponies were otherwise occupied), and they ran according to a schedule so regular that one could set a clock by it — if hobbits had any liking for clocks, which they mostly did not. From sunrise to nightfall, the lanes carried their little traffic, looping between hamlets, holes, and market-greens:

- **Morning carts**, departing at first light, bore milk, cream, and the freshest butter to Bywater and Hobbiton, arriving just in time for the setting of the first market stalls.
- **Noon carts** ran heavier, piled with baked goods, barrels of ale, bunches of pipeweed, and the odd bundle of letters sealed with red wax — though such letters were scarce, and regarded with great curiosity by the post-hobbits.
- **Afternoon carts** ferried folk themselves: cousins visiting cousins, aunties on small errands, or the occasional gentlehobbit heading to a tea engagement of extreme importance.
- **Evening carts**, fewer in number, bore back empty barrels and weary hobbits, their arms laden with turnips, potatoes, cheeses, and the sorts of small, necessary treasures a market day yields.
- **Night carts** existed only in song and rumour — for no respectable hobbit travelled after dark unless compelled by grave need or mischief.

The patterns of these carts were now so ingrained that there was hardly a hobbit from Tighfield to Tookbank who could not tell you precisely when the South Lane pony-cart would pass the old oak, or when the Hillfoot ale-wagon was due at Bywater Pool. Children would sit on fences counting them, and more than one young lad or lass grew up dreaming of taking the reins one day, seeing the whole of the Shire from behind a pony's twitching ears.

Of course, disagreements arose — they always did when hobbits and schedules were involved. Should the noon cart from Whitfurrows wait for the luncheon pies cooling in Overhill, or press on and risk the pies growing cold by teatime? Such matters were debated at the inns with a seriousness that other folks reserve for kings and crowns.

If you wandered the lanes of Hobbiton in those days, you would not have heard a single bell toll the hours, not at sunrise, nor noon, nor sunset. Such contrivances belonged to the tall-folk, and the Shire had little use for them. It is said in the Red Book that the men of Gondor had perfected the art of marking the day. In the rebuilt courts of the King, there were fine bronze bells set high in the towers, their chimes carrying over the Pelennor Fields, so that all folk might know precisely when the hour had turned.

Some of these tidings travelled northwards, and there were even whispers that a trader or two from Gondor had brought such devices as far as Bree, where the Prancing Pony still bustled on cold evenings. Breefolk, shrewd in their way, liked the idea well enough. They mounted a small, rather dented bell atop the east gable of the Pony and began ringing it though no one could quite agree whether it tolled for the proper hour, the arrival of ale-carts, or simply the innkeeper's fancy.

But in the Shire, bells found no root. There, time was counted by other means by the rooster's crow, the sun falling across the Hill, the distant rumble of market-carts upon the Bywater Road, or the smell of seed-cakes cooling on a windowsill. A Hobbit rose when the light was warm, rested when his belly was full, and took no great care whether it was the third hour or the sixth. So it had been

for a thousand years, and so it would have remained were it not for the brief and bitter memory of the Scouring.

For there had been a time long before the Hundredth Year of the Fourth Age, though the elders still spoke of it over their pipes, when outside folk had come with their wagons, their rules, and their ledgers, intent on making the Shire "better." Better roads, they said, and better order, and better accounts of what belonged to whom. Under the sway of Lotho Sackville-Baggins and his unsavoury allies, chimneys were raised, mills were broken down and rebuilt larger, and a kind of Shire time was imposed, with horns blown at morning and dusk, as though Hobbits needed reminding when to rise and when to sup.

The attempt lasted but a season, for everyone knows what followed: the return of Mr. Frodo, Mr. Samwise Gamgee, who was Mayor, and their companions from the far wars, and the raising of the Shire once more to its proper state. The horns were silenced, the smoke cleared, and the old ways of measuring time returned, that is to say, hardly measuring it at all.

2. Hobbit-Architecture

Once, a respectable hobbit-hole was thought quite complete as it was—a proper, snug burrow with round doors and round windows, warm hearths, and cellars deep enough to keep one's cheese from sweating in the summer months. Yet, as families grew and fortunes shifted (and there was more of both than in Bilbo's time), many hobbits took to enlarging their smials, adding wings and side-passages in ways that would have astonished even the Old Took himself.

The more traditional-minded among them—particularly the old gaffers leaning on their gate-posts—insisted that "a hobbit ought to live in a hole in the ground" and declared that square windows and flat doors were "unnatural" and "quite against the grain." Yet even in the grandest new extensions, one would never find a square corner to knock one's head upon. The stonework, where it was used, was gently curved, and any wood was planed and bent into soft arcs. Roundness remained the chief hallmark of Hobbit architecture—round windows, round doors, round cupboards, round everything where it could be managed. A square window in Hobbiton, it was said, "lets in draughts and misfortune alike."

What began as modest kitchen wings and extra pantries tucked discreetly beneath hills soon grew bolder. Certain families—notably the Bracegirdles in Tuckborough and the Cotton brothers along the Water—began to think vertically. A few daring builders raised upper chambers with wide dormer windows, and in Hobbiton there was even, briefly, the scandal of a three-storey millhouse, its tiled roof visible from across the Bywater. Many muttered at this, saying that "a proper Hobbit lives under the earth, not upon it," and that digging deep was the way of their folk since before the founding of the Shire.

But younger Hobbits, having encountered Men upon the Great East Road or heard tales from wandering Dwarves, grew curious about timbered frames, tiled gables, and broad porches where one might sit for Afternoon Tea. The influence came from many sources: traders out of Gondor who rode up through Bree with silver-belled clocks and clever joinery, wandering Dwarves carrying carved lintels and tales of stone-vaulted chambers beneath Erebor, and even passing Elves—it was said that the first round skylights in Tuckborough had been inspired by a company out of Lindon who tarried there one spring.

By the mid-1500s S.R., the architectural divide had grown pronounced. Tuckborough, seat of the Took clan, became known for its ornamentation—finer brickwork, carved stone doorframes, and iron hinges fashioned by skilled smiths who apprenticed under wandering Dwarves from the Blue Mountains. Smiths and cartwrights began using iron brackets and leaded glass brought from the Men of Lake-town, while fletchers left their marks with arrow-etched shutters above their doorways, hinting at Tookish prowess in distant battles.

In contrast, Hobbiton preferred a plainer look, though its craftwork was no less clever. Where Bag End had long stood as the model of comfortable gentility, the most respected smials remained dug into the chalk and clay of The Hill, their deep roots keeping the summer heat away and holding the warmth in winter. The older families—the Boffins, Chubbs, and Proudfoots (Proudfeet, as they insist)—preferred restraint, arguing over mugs of ale at The Green Dragon that a hobbit-hole was not merely a home but a philosophy: round, soft, and steady, much like the folk themselves. Cartwrights, fletchers, and coopers set up discreet workshops just off the lanes, while millers along the Water perfected the balance of stone and timber needed to keep the grinding-wheels steady through every season.

The smithies were particularly prized throughout the Shire, for metal was dear and rarely wasted. A well-wrought hinge, latch, or cooking-pot could last through five generations of Hobbits if properly tended, and so the names of certain master-smiths endured in quiet fame: Holman Grubb, whose copper kettles were said to "sing sweeter than any bird," or Rudibald Rumble of Tuckborough, who once forged a weather-vane shaped like a dragon—though he claimed not to know why.

The tensions were not merely aesthetic. Old Gammer Brownlock of Overhill declared with some heat that these "high houses" smelled of pride and folly both, claiming they'd leak in the spring rains and that "good, honest earth was wrought to be lived in, not scoffed at." Letters survive of minor quarrels between cousins disputing garden heights, roof slopes, and even the number of round windows a proper hobbit-hole might bear.

What the old guard called "showiness," the younger folk defended as "practical improvement." And indeed, there was sense in some of it. Larders grew deeper and cooler by clever stonework; skylights over kitchens made morning baking easier; new-built lofts became fine spaces for drying herbs or curing leaf. Yet among the Bagginses, Brandybucks, and Boffins, a firm belief endured: to rise too far above the good earth was to court trouble, and "those who meddle with the airs of Men may find their pies burnt and their pantries bare," as one old proverb went.

But the Shire was not so quick to forget itself. For every ambitious Tookish window or bold Brandybuck balcony, there were five steady Proudfoot doorways dug deep into the banks, their round frames polished smooth by generations of hands. And if any outsider thought this fashioning-up marked a change in hobbit hearts, they need only attend a market day to find the truth unchanged: six meals a day, and seven if supper ran late, mattered more than any gable or gilded hinge.

3. Concerning-Pipeweed

Though the hobbits were never a travelling folk by habit, it was their cultivation of pipe-weed that first brought men with any regularity to the borders of the Shire. Long before dwarf-carts clattered through the Eastfarthing on the Great Road, or Gondorian traders tested the markets of Bree, there were already lean, long-limbed men from the Southfarthing lanes to the Brandywine crossing, standing in mild awe of the small folk who had contrived such a curious pleasure. To smoke a pipe

of dried leaf was still, even a century into the Fourth Age, spoken of abroad as “the hobbit’s art,” and it remained their most renowned invention outside their borders.

Of the many varieties, three were still most widely reckoned and most fondly remembered: Longbottom Leaf, with its soft and even burn, most often carried in purses by respectable farmers and millers; Old Toby, darker and fuller, a favourite of gaffers and uncles whose talk grew deeper as the night went on; and Southern Star, rare in the Northfarthing, but cherished in inns, being lively in fragrance and much associated with merriment. Each bore not only a distinct taste but also a subtle reputation among hobbits themselves, so that to fill a pipe with Southern Star at a gathering was thought a little bold, while Old Toby suggested an evening of serious talk.

The trade in pipe-weed brought men—merchants of Bree, factors from Gondor on longer journeys, and even stray wanderers from Dale or the Blue Mountains—to the borders of the Shire, and sometimes across them. Some came to the Southfarthing farms themselves, and more often than not were politely received, though closely watched; for hobbits kept jealous guard on their fields, the curing barns, and the secrets of leaf preparation. Gold coin clinked in those transactions, for men brought more wealth than barter, and yet the hobbits thought little of the riches it might bring. To them, pipe-weed was a pleasure and a part of daily custom, not an export to make fortunes. Still, the roads by Longbottom grew busier in harvest-tide, and the inns of Bywater and Tuckborough might see strange faces at their benches, eager to taste the leaf fresh from the farms that had given it birth.

Even into the Fourth Age, when trade and travel in Eriador had grown more settled, it was still whispered in taverns from Bree to Minas Tirith that the Shire-folk had some hidden magic in the soil, or secret fire in their curing ovens, that gave their leaf its unmatched flavour. Yet the hobbits would only smile, draw a slow breath on their pipes, and answer nothing. For though men had borrowed much from them, the smoke rising into the air on a still evening was still most truly hobbitish, and so it remained.

With this growing fame, however, came a slow and subtle shifting of Shire-life. Men began to appear more frequently at its edges — on the Green Hills to the west, along the Brandywine Bridge, and upon the lanes near Sarn Ford. They came not as raiders nor as emissaries, but as traders: long-limbed, plain-faced men out of Bree, or wandering Rohirrim who had learned the habit during their sojourns in Gondor and now sought barrels to bring home.

This stirred some unease among the more conservative Hobbit families, who muttered that the Shire should not be troubled by “outside dealings.” The memory of Sharkey’s Men was not yet two generations old, and there were still those in Tuckborough and Hobbiton alike who viewed strangers on the road with wary eyes. Yet others, especially among the Southfarthing planters, welcomed the traffic, for it brought silver pennies and small luxuries from distant lands dyed fabrics from Lebennin, copper trinkets from Dale, and even, on rare occasions, fragments of dwarven craft from Erebor itself.

Thus pipe-weed, though seemingly small in the ordering of things, had become by the early decades of the Fourth Age a quiet hinge upon which the Shire’s relations with the wider world turned. And though Hobbits never sought to be known beyond their own borders, their leaf — and their habit — had travelled far, earning both envy and imitation.

4. Of a Curious Trade and a Little Box

It came to pass long before the present year of history, in an age when the Shire was still tending its gardens and markets in the slow, deliberate rhythm of peace that a small and strange object entered the borders of Tookland. It arrived not with any great clatter or herald, nor through schemes of Men or Elves, but by simple trade, as many things of consequence often do.

The object was a coffer, small and precise, its surface of polished black wood inlaid with patterns that neither Hobbit nor Man could wholly read. There were no hinges, no lock, yet the joinery was exact beyond the skill of ordinary craft. Some said the patterns were runes, though no scholar of Gondor, Bree, or the Shire could make them out. Others whispered that they were echoes of a long-forgotten music, a relic of the shaping of the world itself, though such tales reached the Shire slowly, if at all.

It was long in the possession of the Tooks, though how it first came into their hands is a story half-forgotten even among them. Some said a wandering trader from Bree had brought it, offering it for a bag of silver or a rare pipeweed, and that the first Took who purchased it did so with a mixture of curiosity and simple delight. Others claimed it arrived from a distant land, a gift or a spoil of some wandering adventure, but no record remained to confirm either tale.

Over the generations, it had quietly taken root in the family's household. Its presence — subtle, unnerving, and oddly compelling — is said to have lent the Tooks that peculiar reputation for curiosity and mischief that endured through the ages. They were seldom dangerous, these Hobbits, but they did sometimes act in ways that startled their neighbours: a borrowed horse returned too late, a garden fence left oddly askew, a picnic moved mysteriously in the night. Such events were small, yet cumulatively gave the Tooks their reputation, as if some unseen spirit of the world had lodged itself in their lineage.

By the time of Marlo Took, great-grandson of Pippin, the coffer rested upon a low table beneath a window looking toward the Brandywine. Hobbits might handle it, examine it, and even place small treasures within, yet its true nature remained veiled. It was not a tool of dominion, like the Rings of Power of old, nor did it offer temptation of mastery. Rather, it was something older, subtler, and less forgiving: a vessel of possibilities, of forces unshaped and lingering since the earliest shaping of the world.

Men, passing through Bree or trading along the Greenway, noticed its strangeness. Some suspected it was of Númenórean make; others feared it might be a key to secrets long lost in the southern lands. Dwarves, if they caught sight of its joinery, remarked upon its impossibility. Elves, had any wandered so far, might have recognized echoes of the Music of the Ainur in its delicate patterns, though none were present to do so.

And so it rested quietly in Tookland. Hobbits continued their lives as before, tending gardens, trading pipe-weed, and enjoying the gentle rotations of meals and market days. Yet to the attentive reader, or the chronicler who might write of these things centuries later, the black coffer represented a thread stretching outwards from the small world of the Shire to mysteries far older and wider than hedgerows, pastures, and stone-bridged streams.

The coffer, though silent and immobile, had a way of drawing notice, though no Hobbit ever claimed to hear it speak. Its presence in Tookland had been long enough for it to leave traces, though these were seldom understood. A basket of apples might topple unexpectedly, or a simple supper of buttered bread and cheese would turn unusually sour, though the milk had been fresh that very morning. Hobbits would remark on such things in passing: "Took luck, they say," or "There

goes another of their curious ways.” It was rarely anything grave, yet enough to give the quiet air of the Shire a peculiar tension.

Marlo Took, accustomed to these minor wonders from childhood, sometimes noticed that thoughts came unbidden when he was near the coffer. Ideas of distant lands, of adventures beyond the Shire, of curious and sometimes troubling possibilities, drifted through his mind. He attributed it at first to reading too much, or perhaps to the wandering of his own family’s restless blood. Yet the coffer was never far from thought, and often, when he reached for it, it seemed heavier than its size suggested, as though the world itself leaned upon it.

Neighbors of the Took, of course, were quick to comment. “There’s something about that family,” they said, “something that stirs the air itself.” Occasionally, a bird would vanish from a branch, or a garden tool would move a step or two overnight; such things were whispered of, and then forgotten, dismissed as Tookish whimsy. But even the eldest Hobbits, who remembered the War of the Ring and the strange times that followed, could not fully explain the sensation of small, persistent unrest that seemed to follow the coffer wherever it rested.

It was said in Bree that such objects were rare and seldom understood. Traders and wandering scholars spoke of “containers of beginnings,” relics formed in the shaping of the world, before even the might of Morgoth or the darkness of Sauron had settled upon Arda. Some of these objects were said to contain seeds of chaos, forces too old and diffuse to be bound or directed. Others claimed that they merely held possibility, that the world itself shaped their influence according to those who encountered them. Whatever the truth, the Took’s black coffer had earned its quiet legend: subtle, persistent, and unsettling, it had long prepared the ground for deeds, great or small, that might shape the Shire and perhaps even wider realms in years to come.

In this way, the coffer linked the ordinary rhythms of Hobbit life to the deeper currents of the world. Market days continued, meals rotated with faithful regularity, and the fields and gardens of Tookland thrived as before. And yet, those who observed carefully — or who would read these events in the Red Book centuries later — might notice that a small, dark box had begun to awaken the restless tendencies of the Took, hinting that the quiet corners of the Shire were not so tranquil as they appeared.

Thus it rested, through the passing years, a small, dark sentinel of possibility. The Took, as ever, were known for their curiosity, but it was quiet curiosity now, a family trait gently sharpened over time. And all the while, the coffer waited — a witness to the peaceful rhythms of the Shire, to meals and market days, to gardens and hedgerows — as if aware that, in its own time, the world might need it, or perhaps that it would need the world.

Chapter One

The Took, it was said, had a way of courting trouble without meaning to. They didn’t set out to look for it, you understand — they were *hobbits*, after all, and hobbits prefer comfort to calamity — but somehow trouble always found them, as it finds a door left slightly ajar.

Marlo Took was no different, though he swore up and down that he was a quiet sort, “not one for adventures,” as he would often mutter while stacking his pipeweed tins. On most days, he kept a tidy little routine in his snug hole at the western edge of Tuckborough: up at seven bells, breakfast promptly thereafter, a quick stroll to market, and then back home to tend his shelves and keep his tea hot.

And yet, there was always... *something* about Marlo. A glint in the eye when he spoke of far-off places, an extra spring in his step when strangers passed through the Green Dragon, a habit of keeping curious company when traders came to Bree. Folk whispered that Tookishness was in his bones, and that once a Took, always a Took, no matter how hard one tried to live a quiet life.

He swung his legs from the bed and padded to the window, yawning, looking out over the green slopes that fell gently toward the Tookbank. A little mist still clung in the valley, where the Brandywine curved like a silver thread, but here on the rise the air smelled of damp earth, budding flowers, and the faintest hint of woodsmoke from his neighbours' chimneys.

Today was Market Day in Tookbank, and Marlo had promised himself — rather firmly — that he would go.

He dressed in a brown waistcoat and an old green jacket that had seen better years, stuffed a small cloth purse with two half-pennies and a thumb-sized twist of pipe-leaf for barter, and went down to the kitchen, where he set about buttering a hunk of bread and cutting a slice of cheese. Breakfast first — always breakfast first — and then the road.

The Tookbank Market was only a half-hour walk from the smial if one took the meadow path, which Marlo always did. There was the lane past the thorn trees, down over the stile where the hedge sagged a little, and then a sloping trail that curled through sheep-cropped hills and ended at the market square: a patch of cobbles no wider than a farmer's field, ringed with low shops and temporary stalls.

The market square itself lay nestled in a shallow dip, bounded by a crooked ring of low shops and trader-stalls, their timbered fronts painted in faded colours: russet, cream, soft sage-green. Wooden awnings bowed under the weight of hanging herbs and pots, and a slow, comforting hum of voices rose from the cobbles as hobbits milled and mingled, baskets under arms, shaking heads or clucking tongues at the price of butter, flour, or pipe-leaf.

When Marlo arrived, the market was already lively with chatter. Farmers in their workboots stood arguing cheerfully over the price of early peas, while the fishmonger — a stout Hobbit with a voice like a cracked bell — shouted offers about the morning's catch from the Brandywine. Bakers, tinkers, gardeners, and gooseherds crowded together beneath striped awnings, their tables set with everything from goose eggs and honeycomb to carved trinkets and jars of last year's preserves.

Marlo moved among them with his usual cheer, though he felt the familiar stares prickling at the back of his neck. Tookbank Hobbits were polite — as a rule — but everyone *knew* about the Took. A family too curious by half, forever poking their noses into trouble, and far too fond of *strange* things. Old tales whispered in back rooms said that the Took blood had been touched by something *other* long ago, and though most would laugh if asked, the laughter was always just a little too quick.

Marlo paused by a fishmonger's stall, nodding politely.

"Morning, young Took," said Aldo Bramble, a stout fellow whose cheeks were already flushed from hauling baskets up from the river. "You're late enough that the biggest trout's gone, but there's some fine grayling left."

Marlo smiled. "I'm after eggs today, Aldo, but I'll come back round if there's any coin left in my pocket."

“Don’t wait too long,” Aldo warned, jerking his chin at a sharp-eyed lass from Bywater already weighing a string of silver-bellied fish.

Marlo ambled on, taking in the gentle currents of life flowing around him. Old Gerda Chubb was arguing with a farmer over the weight of his carrots, and nearby two hobbit children darted beneath a stall, their laughter tangling with the market sounds like sunlight through leaves.

And there, just beyond the herb-seller’s table, stood Rory Bolger, leaning on a cane and sipping from a chipped mug of cider. Rory was the closest thing Tookbank had to a chronicler; he knew every bit of news, every marriage pact, every old grudge three generations deep. It was impossible to pass him without learning something—whether you wanted to or not.

“Morning, Marlo!” Rory called, beckoning him over with a crooked finger. “Have you heard? That Brownlock lad from Frogmorton’s gone and painted his round-door yellow. Yellow!” He shook his head gravely, as though this heralded the decline of the Shire entire.

Marlo bit back a grin and nodded solemnly, as though sharing the weight of this calamity. “A shocking thing indeed,” he said. “I suppose the Riverfolk will be wanting blue doors next.”

“Oh, don’t jest about such matters,” Rory muttered, sipping noisily at his cider. “It starts with yellow, but who knows where it ends.”

They stood for a time beneath the warm, growing sun, and Marlo let the conversation meander the way Hobbit talk always did, winding through turnips, weather, and weddings until it finally circled back upon itself like an old song.

Only later, after Marlo had bought his eggs, traded a handful of barley-cakes for a pouch of good pipe-weed, and swapped greetings with three cousins and an aunt, did he catch wind of something stranger—a whisper, passing between two stallholders near the weaver’s bench. He didn’t catch every word, but there was something about Bree, and a trader, and trouble brewing where strangers walked too freely.

The morning deepened, and with it the hum of the Tookbank market. By the time Marlo reached the green, the square was alive with chatter and the low music of barter. Stalls, little more than stout trestle-tables set beneath awnings patched and faded by many summers, lined the cobbled ring around the well. The old stone of the square, warmed by long years of hobbit feet, seemed to gather the sun and hold it, so that even in early spring there was a comfort in lingering there.

Marlo wound his way between baskets of early turnips, pots of honey glinting like captured light, and piles of bright green nettle-cheeses that gave off a sharp, clean scent. A group of gaffers stood near the smithy door, pipes drawing lazily, talking low of weather and water-rights. Elsewhere, a pair of young hobbits haggled fiercely over the price of a second-hand kettle, while the baker’s apprentice darted between stalls with a wicker tray of sweetseed rolls still warm from the oven.

There was an ease in the air, a rhythm built from countless market-days much like this one: the same calls of hawkers, the same laughter, the same small quarrels that never truly soured. Tookbank folk, as a rule, liked their dealings plain and their mornings untroubled.

It was because of this, perhaps, that Marlo noticed him at once.

He stood apart, near the shaded edge of the square where the oak roots pushed through the cobbles — a tall fellow, by hobbit reckoning, though still shorter than any Man proper. His cloak was travel-

worn, cut in the rough Bree-fashion, and the iron buckle at his shoulder caught the sun with a muted gleam. Beside him stood a small handcart, its wheels crusted with half the roads of the Westfarthing, and upon it were stacked curious bundles wrapped in oilskin.

The trader — for trader he plainly was — bore himself with the quiet patience of one used to long roads and slow bargains. His face was browned by weather and his boots showed hard miles, yet his eyes were keen and quick, scanning the market like a man reading a map.

Marlo hesitated, clutching his small purse of coppers. Outsiders were rare at Tookbank market, rarer still those from Bree. There were murmurs already among the nearby folk, and more than one suspicious glance cast his way. No one quite trusted Bree-folk — too many stories of sly dealing, queer rumours, and the unsettling habit of carrying tales back and forth along the Greenway.

But something in the trader's manner — steady, unhurried, almost courteous in his stillness — drew Marlo closer.

He cleared his throat. "You've come a fair way, I reckon," he said, trying for a casual tone.

The man turned his gaze down upon him and smiled — not broadly, but as if he had been expecting him.

It was then, just as he was haggling for a small bag of barley, that Marlo noticed the hush. A ripple ran through the crowd — subtle at first, like the breeze shifting the leaves, but unmistakable if one was listening. Hobbits paused mid-bargain, heads turning towards the eastern lane. A figure had appeared at the far edge of the green, walking slowly, deliberately, and so it seemed to Marlo *lightly*, as though his boots barely pressed the earth.

He was tall for a hobbit, though not so tall as a Man. Lean, willow-limbed, with a long dark coat the colour of wet ash, and a hood drawn low over his brow. His hair, what could be seen of it, fell in silvered strands that caught the sunlight like a thread of moonlight tangled in shadow. He moved differently than most folk of the Shire: not with the solid, grounded gait of hobbits, but with a curious ease — as though he belonged partly to another place, far older than Tookbank and deeper-rooted than its gentle hills.

Marlo frowned, adjusting the bag of barley beneath his arm.

"Who's that, then?" he muttered under his breath, though Old Rummel had already retreated behind his carrots.

The newcomer reached the edge of the market and, without haste, set down a travelling pack of soft, weather-worn leather. From it he drew a small roll of pale linen and began to lay out his wares upon a stall abandoned long ago by an unlucky turnip seller. A scatter of objects emerged, placed carefully one by one on the faded cloth: delicate bottles sealed with wax, fragments of stone etched with faint runes, silver trinkets carved like tangled branches, and strange, folded maps whose ink shimmered faintly in the light.

The whispers began almost at once.

"Come all the way from Bree, I heard," someone said behind Marlo's shoulder.

"Looks half-elvish, doesn't he?" said another. "Look at those ears — not quite round, you see?"

"Never trust Bree-traders," came a third voice, lower and more suspicious. "Strangers bring strangers' troubles."

Marlo ignored them. He found himself staring, though he wasn't entirely sure why. There was something about the man — or hobbit, or whatever he was — that seemed... out of step with the rest of the market. He didn't speak like the other traders, nor shout his prices, nor boast of his wares. He simply set them out in silence, his hands deft and sure, as though he *knew* anyone who came close enough would see their worth without a word said.

At last, the stranger raised his head, his hood slipping back a fraction, and Marlo caught the glint of his eyes — grey as the River Lune beneath clouded skies.

Their gazes met only for a heartbeat. Marlo felt something stir, like the sudden awareness of standing on a threshold without knowing what lay beyond. He couldn't have said why, but he had the distinct sense that whatever this traveller carried — be it stories, secrets, or something stranger still — it did not belong to Tookbank.

The stranger inclined his head slightly, almost a bow, and said softly:

“Elric Bramblethorn, at your service.”

His voice was low and even, carrying the lilting cadence of Bree, though there was something else beneath it — something faintly musical, as though the words had been shaped by another tongue before they ever reached the Common Speech.

Marlo shifted his weight uneasily, his furry toes curling against the packed earth of the market square. He gave a polite half-bow in return, tugging at the hem of his waistcoat.

“Marlo Took,” he said, his voice quieter than he intended. “At yours... and your family's.”

The proper words were spoken, yet he could not shake the prickling at the nape of his neck. Elric Bramblethorn — a name that did not belong in the Shire, or anywhere near Tookbank, for that matter.

Around them, the market clattered and murmured: the crackle of roasting chestnuts on iron pans, the soft whicker of ponies tethered to rails, the sing-song of hobbit voices bartering over cheese and pipe-leaf. But here, between the barrels of pickled beets and a cart stacked with green apples, the air seemed to settle strangely, as if holding its breath.

Marlo's dark eyes flicked over the stranger's wares — spread carefully on a strip of deep-blue cloth atop a wooden crate. There were small glass vials stoppered with wax, catching the sunlight like droplets of frozen morning dew. A string of silver fishhooks, curved and cunningly barbed, finer than any a hobbit hand could make. A small bundle of something that looked like dried starflowers, white as snow, bound tightly in silver thread. And a single black feather — glossy and too large by half for any bird Marlo knew.

Not the sort of goods that were traded in Tookbank. Not the sort of goods most hobbits would welcome.

“You've come a fair way, Master Bramblethorn,” Marlo said, trying to keep his tone light, though curiosity gnawed at him. “What brings you to the Shire? Most from Bree pass us by on their road to Hobbiton, or else turn back 'fore they reach these parts.”

Elric's pale-grey eyes — cool, sharp, unsettlingly still — met Marlo's.

"I travel where the roads allow," he said, his voice low and measured. "And where they do not, I make my own."

Marlo swallowed, resisting the urge to glance over his shoulder, though he was sure more than a few nearby hobbits were watching them closely. It wasn't that Bree-folk were forbidden here — though half the Shire would rather they were — but the sight of an outsider, especially one this strange, could set the talk running faster than a Took at a wedding feast.

Behind them, old Lyle Burrows, the cheesemonger, was leaning against his stall, pretending to polish a wheel of brie while his eyes stayed fixed on Elric. Beyond him, Marlo caught snippets of hushed voices:

"Who's he then?"

"Not right, that one... look at the boots!"

"Half-elf blood, if I'm any judge."

Marlo stiffened slightly. Half-elf. He'd thought it too, though he'd kept it to himself: there was something in Elric's face, a fine-boned sharpness beneath the Bree-weathered skin, and that faint music in his speech...

Elric seemed to notice the scrutiny, though he gave no sign of caring. Instead, he gently drew a small cloth aside and revealed one last item: a slender box, carved from dark walnut, the grain swirling like storm-clouds. It was no bigger than a loaf of seed-cake, yet it seemed heavier somehow, as though the weight within was greater than wood alone.

"Not for sale," Elric murmured, seeing Marlo's gaze settle on it.

"I wasn't... asking," Marlo said quickly, though he could not quite pull his eyes away.

For a moment, the sounds of the market seemed to recede, until there was only the faint creak of a rope swinging in the warm breeze, the scent of apple cores and pipe-smoke, and the strange, patient silence between the two of them.

Then Elric gave the smallest of nods and began arranging his wares again, as though the moment had not passed, as though the box had never been there at all.

Marlo lingered.

He ought, by all sensible accounts, to have tipped his cap and turned back to his errands — a respectable hobbit would have done so without thinking. Yet the Tookish blood, restless as ever, would not let him. He stood by a barrow piled with late-autumn apples, pretending to compare their gloss and colour, though his eyes kept straying towards the stranger.

Elric Bramblethorn — the name itself sat oddly in Marlo's mind, tasting of two soils at once. His wares, spread out in modest measure upon a threadbare cloth, were stranger still: small pouches tied with fine cord, bottles of something pale and glimmering that caught the light like riverwater, a handful of dark nuts Marlo did not recognise, and lengths of finely-woven cloth shot through with faint green threads that seemed to shimmer when you weren't looking straight at them.

The Shirefolk were not ignoring him, though they pretended to. Mrs. Pennyfoot, passing by with a basket of herbs, glanced sharply at Marlo's boots — muddy from the edge of the riverbank, as though seeking proof of mischief — before turning away with a sniff. Old Tobman Proudbarrow muttered to his neighbour loud enough for several to hear:

“Mark my words, there’s no good comes of Bree-folk in Tookbank. A Took’ll be the first to stir trouble, if trouble’s to be had.”

Marlo felt the weight of it — the sidelong looks, the faint, twitching unease rippling among the market-goers — and all the more, he couldn’t leave.

Elric stood quite still, watching the crowd without watching them, his dark green cloak drawing the chill of the wind as if it belonged to it. There was something unhurried about him, something quiet and self-contained. Not dangerous, Marlo told himself — not exactly — but *unfamiliar*.

And *unfamiliar* was perilous in the Shire.

Still, he drifted closer, beneath the pretence of studying a wheel of pale cheese on a nearby stall. The closer he came, the more details he noticed. Elric’s ears — half-hidden beneath his hood — were not pointed, not entirely, but neither were they rounded like any hobbit’s. His boots were supple leather, well-made, though worn by long miles. His hair was dark with faint copper tones, a little wild, like tangled autumn bracken.

Marlo cleared his throat — softly, but it sounded loud in his ears.

“You’ve come far, Master Bramblethorn,” he said at last, mustering what he hoped was a casual tone.

Elric’s head turned, and the faintest curve of a smile touched his lips. “Far enough,” he replied. “Though I’ve been further.”

Something in the way he said it unsettled Marlo and drew him closer in the same breath. A murmur passed through a knot of hobbits behind them — Mrs. Pennyfoot again, whispering fiercely to Mrs. Tunnelly about *strangers and their strange doings*.

Marlo glanced about, saw the faces half-averted, and for the first time in many weeks, felt that Tookish defiance stir in him like an ember catching wind. Let them look. Let them gossip. He straightened slightly, pretending more confidence than he felt.

“Well,” Marlo said, clearing his throat again, “if you’ve come as far as Bree, you’ve come far indeed. There’s little comfort to be had at the Greenman this time of year — damp beds and cold stew, if I recall it right.”

Elric’s eyes — grey-green, sharp and calm — met his. “I’ve slept colder,” he said simply.

And before Marlo could stop himself, before the voices of Mrs. Pennyfoot and Old Proudbarrow could turn him back, he heard the words leave his mouth:

“Then you’d best come to mine. A warm hearth, at least, and a bit of supper. No sense letting a traveller freeze when Tookbank’s got the means to keep him fed.”

There was a silence at that — not from Elric, who only watched him with that faint, unreadable expression — but from those behind. The soft hiss of whispers grew sharper, like dry grass in a wind.

A Took inviting a stranger in.

And worse: Marlo Took.

Elric inclined his head once more, that almost-bow.

“I would be glad of it.”

Marlo hesitated only a moment before turning back to Elric.

“Well... well, if you’ve nowhere set to stay,” he said, rubbing his thumb absently against his palm, “it’s no trouble to walk with me awhile. I’ve tea enough at home, and my hearth keeps better than most.”

Elric’s dark eyes flickered, catching the pale afternoon light, and for the briefest instant, something unreadable passed across his face — a thought withheld, or perhaps a memory. Then, with the smallest incline of his head, he said:

“I would be honoured.”

Marlo cleared his throat, nodded briskly, and gestured for the trader to follow him through the winding lane that led away from the Tookbank market square.

The afternoon was mellowing into a soft gold, though a thin, pearled haze still hung over the edges of the River Ash. The cobbled lanes of Tookbank were narrow and crooked, lined with their familiar smials tucked beneath grassy knolls, each round door painted in soft, cheerful colours: sage greens, buttery yellows, and russet reds. Smoke drifted lazily from several chimneys, carrying the scent of applewood fires and sugared scones cooling on windowsills.

And yet, as Marlo and Elric walked, the usual easy rhythms of Tookbank shifted, ever so slightly. Conversations paused as the two passed; pipe smoke hung suspended in the air as a dozen pairs of eyes turned to follow them, unashamedly curious. A Bree trader was rare enough in these parts, but Elric was stranger still: taller than any hobbit, narrower in the face, his cloak travelling-worn but finer in its cut than the sort most Bree-folk afforded. There was, in the shimmer of his eyes and the quiet precision of his steps, something that set him subtly apart from both Hobbit and Man.

Marlo could feel the weight of the glances. A few mutters drifted from porches and open windows — names whispered, remarks exchanged behind hands.

“Trust a Took to bring strangeness down the lane...”

“Mark my words, nothing good comes of dealings over Bree-way...”

“...half their trouble’s made from curiosity, and the other half from pride.”

Marlo caught enough of it to redden at the ears, but he said nothing, only walked a little faster, his hands buried in his waistcoat pockets.

Elric, for his part, moved with a calm that bordered on indifference. If he heard the murmurs, he gave no sign of it. But Marlo, quick-eyed as any Took, thought he saw the stranger’s gaze linger once or twice on the curve of a hill, the weave of a hedge, or the weathered carvings above a smial door — the kind of seeing that seemed deeper than simple curiosity, as though Elric were measuring the quiet heart of the Shire against something older and far away.

They crossed a small stone bridge arched over the streamlet where Tookbank children dangled their feet and splashed at dragonflies. One of the lads, bold as you like, called out:

“Who’s your tall friend, Master Marlo? Got any magic beans for us?”

Marlo flushed, muttered something about manners, and lengthened his stride. Elric, though, turned his head slightly and offered the child a faint smile. It was brief, soft, and gone as quickly as it came — but the boy fell silent, staring wide-eyed as though he'd glimpsed something unexpected, perhaps even a little uncanny.

By the time they reached the quieter lanes beyond the square, the market noises had faded, replaced by the gentle sigh of the river and the rustle of oak leaves overhead. Marlo's home lay on the western edge of Tookbank, half-buried beneath a low rise of grass and crowned by a single tall ash tree.

As they drew near, Marlo hesitated at the little gate, resting his hand on the latch. He glanced sidelong at Elric, unsure how to put into words the nervous flutter beneath his ribs. The stories of his kin — the Tookish taste for oddness, for straying beyond hedgerows and fences — had been whispered about him since he was a boy. Now here he was, walking home with a stranger draped in mystery, feeling every stare of every hobbit behind him.

He swallowed, managing a crooked smile.

"Well," he said at last, pushing open the gate, "best come inside before the whole of Tookbank writes a tale about us. Folk do talk, you know."

Marlo's smial sat at the western bend of Tookbank Lane, nestled snugly into a low hillock above the Bywater Stream, its round green door half-hidden beneath a tangle of honeysuckle and wild rose. By the time he and Elric reached it, the long shadows of afternoon had begun to stretch across the lane, and the market's hum had faded into the soft drone of bees and distant birdsong.

Marlo hesitated a moment with his hand on the round brass knob, glancing sidelong at his guest. Elric Bramblethorn was quiet, his dark-grey cloak stirring faintly in the breeze, his long fingers absently brushing the worn leather strap of his satchel. Behind them, a pair of hobbit-wives passing by slowed just enough to glance back, their whispers trailing like wind through dry reeds. Marlo caught the look — the way it settled on Elric's boots, the cut of his cloak, the faint silver glimmer stitched into the hem — and his cheeks grew warm.

Inside, the smial was cool and low-ceilinged, lined with pale lime-washed walls and shelves crowded with crockery, bundles of dried herbs, and small jars of honey from his cousin Milo's hives. Marlo busied himself at once with the familiar ritual of hospitality: drawing down a tin from the mantle, measuring out a pinch of Old Toby leaf, and filling the polished cherrywood pipes that hung by the hearth.

"Make yourself comfortable, Mr. Bramblethorn," he said, motioning to the low settle by the round window, though his voice carried a slight stiffness, as though the words had been chosen carefully.

Elric inclined his head, folding himself into the seat with surprising grace for one so tall. His satchel he set at his feet, but he rested one hand lightly atop it, as though out of long habit rather than thought.

Marlo lit the pipes, drawing in the first curl of fragrant smoke before passing one across. Elric accepted it without a word, and for a little while they smoked in silence, the smial filling with the soft haze of leaf-smoke that drifted upward and gathered beneath the low beams.

Outside, a dove cooed somewhere in the hedge.

It was Marlo who finally spoke, puffing slowly as though weighing his words against the taste of the pipe:

“You’ve come a fair way, by the look of it.”

“A fair way,” Elric replied, his voice low and smooth. He exhaled a slender ribbon of smoke, watching it curl in the lamplight. “Further than most who find themselves here.”

“That’s so,” Marlo said. He leaned back, scratching absently at his chin, his thoughts wandering uneasily. Tookbank did not often welcome Bree-folk, much less Bree-folk who looked as though they had wandered out of an older tale — for that was the thought that kept pressing itself upon him. There was something in the way Elric’s eyes caught the light, like pale water under starlight, and something in the shape of his words that stirred faint memories he could not place.

Elric seemed content to let the silence grow again, though his gaze moved slowly about the room — the shelves, the round window, the small clutter of Marlo’s life laid bare in plain view. It wasn’t the curious look of a merchant measuring a hobbit’s worth, but something quieter, as though he were noting the texture of the place itself, weighing its patterns and stillness.

Marlo felt a prickle at the nape of his neck.

Marlo had settled himself cross-legged upon the low, rounded stool near the hearth, his hands clasped awkwardly around a mug of warm apple cider. The dim, amber light of the little lamps washed across the smooth, earth-packed walls of the smial, throwing their shadows wide and soft, and the gentle crackle of the fire was the only sound between them for a time. Elric Bramblethorn sat opposite, in the corner where Marlo’s father’s pipe rack hung, his posture relaxed but watchful, one long hand trailing over the carved arm of the chair as though the texture of the wood mattered to him.

The silence, though companionable enough, pressed upon Marlo’s mind. He puffed once upon his pipe, filling the air with the faint, sweet scent of Southfarthing leaf, and after a moment, the words escaped him before he quite thought them through.

“Begging your pardon, Mr. Bramblethorn,” Marlo began, leaning forward a little, “but you said your folk weren’t far from Bree-way, aye? I wondered... are they—are they Shirefolk, then?” He hesitated, fiddling with the rim of his mug. “Only, there’s a manner of your looks, and a manner of your words, that don’t seem wholly... well, hobbit-like, if you take my meaning.”

At this, Elric’s grey-green eyes lifted to Marlo’s, and something faint, some ripple like light on deep water, passed behind them. He did not answer—not with words. Instead, he reached for the small satchel at his side, unfastened a leather thong, and drew forth a curious little whistle, smooth and carved of dark wood, though it seemed older than any craft Marlo knew. He turned it once between his fingers, then set it aside and, quite without preamble, began to sing.

It was no hobbit-song, though some threads of hobbitish tune ran through its heart, like green shoots winding about an ancient stone. The melody rose softly, delicate at first, as though uncertain of its welcome, and then deepened, catching notes that shimmered like starlight falling on water. The words, if words they were, flowed and curved like the running of a stream:

*“Lairessa nimriel thalas,
Under hill and root we roam,*

*Little roads and lantern-glass,
Lead us ever home..."*

Marlo sat very still, pipe forgotten, as Elric's voice twined the gentle turns of a Shire ballad with something older, more haunting, in its pattern. There were stretches of sound he couldn't place at all—half-formed syllables that seemed to belong to a tongue not shaped for mortal lips. Yet now and then the melody touched upon a lilt he knew from childhood, the same rhythm his mother had sung when baking honeycakes on a spring morning.

When the last note faded, soft as wind over meadow-grass, the smial held its breath. Even the fire seemed quieter for a moment. Marlo blinked, throat tight, and managed, after a pause:

"I—I reckon I've heard some o' those tones before. Not the words, maybe, but the sound of 'em. Folk say there's Elvish songs carried by the wind if you're near the Tower Hills, though I've never gone that far west myself. That—was it Elvish?"

Elric smiled faintly, a curve of the lips more knowing than kind, though not unkind.

"Half, perhaps," he said at last, setting the whistle back within its pouch. "And half belonging to another people, nearer your heart than mine. Songs travel further than footsteps, Marlo Took, and older tunes find newer voices."

Marlo chewed upon that in silence, watching the trader's face across the small glow of the hearth, his unease growing softer now, tangled with something else—a slow, creeping wonder, as though the earth beneath his feet had deeper roots than he'd ever guessed.

Outside, the night pressed gently upon the round door, and the faint drip of rain along the ivy told that Tookbank had long since gone to sleep.

Marlo drew deep on his pipe, the ember glowing soft in the dim light of the smial, sending gentle curls of blue smoke toward the low beams. Elric Bramblethorn sat opposite him, cross-legged on a stool far too small for his long frame, his cloak loosened now, revealing a tunic of muted green and a thin cord of silver worked about his neck. He had been speaking of his lineage—half-hobbit, half-elf, though he carried it with a kind of quiet reluctance, as though the words themselves were delicate and might bruise if handled too roughly.

"My mother was from the Westfarthing," Elric had begun, fingers idly tracing the rim of his mug. "A Bramblethorn by name, though they are scattered folk now, more rootless than most hobbits. My father..." He paused, eyes drifting toward the window where the last pale light of day faded beyond the Brandywine. "My father was of the wandering folk, from beyond the borders of the Shire, though his kind seldom spoke of home. They say there is some Silvan blood there, though not enough to make me other, nor quite enough to leave me whole."

He stopped mid-sentence.

Marlo followed his gaze and saw that Elric's sharp grey eyes had settled upon the low table beneath the round window—the place where the little black coffer rested, half-hidden beneath a folded cloth. For a moment, Elric's features shifted, the easy warmth of their talk receding, replaced by something quieter and keener. He rose without a sound, stepping toward it as though drawn by an unseen tether. The room seemed to hush with him.

“This,” he said softly, crouching so that his face was level with the coffer, “this is no common work of hobbit-folk.”

Marlo’s fingers worried the stem of his pipe. “Aye, well, I never said it was. Came by it... oh, years back now. Uncle Berilac left it to me, said it had been knocking about the family since Old Took’s time, though none ever had the luck of opening it.”

Elric’s hand hovered just above its surface, but he didn’t touch it. The polished black wood caught what little light remained, and the faintest suggestion of runes seemed to stir across its lid — or perhaps it was only a trick of the shadows.

“I cannot read these marks,” Elric murmured, his brow furrowing. “They are not Elvish, nor Dwarvish either, unless I miss my guess. Old, though. Older than Bree-folk tales. Older than the Shire itself, perhaps.” His voice dropped to a near whisper, as though mindful of being overheard even in the snug quiet of Marlo’s smial.

Marlo frowned, puffing out a thoughtful ring of smoke. “Uncle Berilac used to say the Took blood ran thick with queer dealings — traders, travellers, strange things passed hand to hand when folk thought no one was looking. There’s a tale, though, from Grandmother Berylla Took, that one of our lot bought it from a wandering peddler on the Greenway — a tall, dark fellow with eyes like starlight and no shadow at his feet.” He chuckled softly, though the sound was thin. “Old story, that.”

Elric glanced back over his shoulder, his face unreadable in the firelight. “Queer, aye... but I would not laugh it off, Marlo. This is no mere keepsake. If what I suspect is true, it may be worth more than the finest harvests of Tookbank ten times over.”

Marlo shifted uneasily on his stool, the warmth of the room suddenly close. “More trouble than treasure, if you ask me. I’ve left it where it is these past years and it’s done me no harm.”

Elric rose slowly, drawing his cloak about him once more. “Perhaps not yet. But mark me, friend — in Bree there are traders who deal in old things, deep things. They keep records few have seen, and their prices are... high, but worth paying. They might know how to wake what sleeps within this coffer. Or, at the very least, who wrought it — and for what purpose.”

Marlo sucked thoughtfully at his pipe, letting the smoke drift between them in long, lazy ribbons. “You think it wise, bringing it to Bree?”

Elric regarded him steadily, his strange grey eyes seeming to catch some reflection of the dying firelight. “Wise? Perhaps not. Necessary? Perhaps so. It calls to questions you do not yet know to ask, Marlo Took. And unanswered questions have a way of growing teeth.”

For a long while, the two sat in silence, the weight of the little coffer between them like an unspoken promise. Outside, the Brandywine murmured softly in the gathering dark, carrying with it the scent of wet earth and distant rain.

“You’re certain you don’t know what’s in it?” Elric’s voice was low, more careful than curious, though there was something keen beneath the surface.

Marlo scratched at the side of his nose. “I’m certain enough. Came by it from Old Garibold Took’s storeroom, and he swore to me he’d had it from a wandering dwarf some thirty years gone —

maybe forty, now. Paid him two pennyweights and a flagon of winter cider for it, though Garibold grumbled he was robbed.”

Elric’s dark eyes stayed fixed upon the coffer, as though he hoped its carvings might shift beneath his gaze. “Dwarves, perhaps... though I’ve seen their marks, and these are not the craft of Durin’s folk. And they are not elvish, either.” He leaned closer, tilting his head, his voice dropping to a murmur. “This is older... much older.”

Marlo puffed a cloud of smoke, trying to sound casual but feeling his heart drum a little faster. “Older than the hills, you’d say, the way you’re looking at it. But what’s a Took to do? Half the old stories tell of cursed boxes and such — full of ghost-fire and wicked dreams. Uncle Marcho once reckoned he’d dug up a chest o’ gold beneath the Old Green Lane, only to find it full of nothing but stones and spiders.”

Elric smiled faintly at that but did not lift his gaze. “And yet... not all tales are so hollow. There are traders in Bree who might know more. Folk who deal in old things — older than even the Greenway, older than the Kings. You might find one who could name these runes, or at least name their makers.” He ran a finger along the faint etchings, hesitating as though afraid to touch them directly.

Marlo shifted uncomfortably in his seat. “And what d’you reckon they’d want for the telling? More than a pennyweight, I’ll wager. Bree-folk have clever tongues, and their pockets always come out heavier than yours.”

Elric chuckled softly, finally turning from the coffer. “Perhaps. Yet knowledge, Master Marlo, is its own kind of coin. If this is what I think it might be...” He trailed off, then sat back, eyes half-shadowed, as though weighing something unseen.

Marlo cleared his throat, pushing himself up from his chair with a quiet grunt. “Well, if it’s Bree we’re to talk of, then we’ll talk on it tomorrow. You’ve walked far enough, I’d say, and I’ve pipesmoke enough in me for one evening.”

He moved toward the small corridor that led to the guest room, its rounded doorway framed by ivy and the faint smell of beeswax polish. “You’re welcome to stay the night, Master Bramblethorn,” Marlo said, trying his best at Tookish hospitality though his mind still lingered on the coffer. “Bed’s soft, blankets are thick, and the kettle’ll be singing come morning.”

Elric rose gracefully, though his eyes flicked one last time to the dark little box beneath the window. “You are most generous, Master Took,” he said softly, his voice carrying something half-hidden — gratitude mingled with a watchfulness Marlo could not quite name.

Marlo merely nodded, puffing once more at his pipe as he padded toward his own chamber. Yet as the lamps dimmed and the night pressed against the round windows, he found his thoughts circling back to the strange runes and the faint, restless glimmer in Elric’s eyes.

The smial had long fallen quiet. Outside, a pale wind brushed over Tookbank, rattling the shutters faintly as if whispering secrets through the wood. Marlo had withdrawn at last, bidding Elric the soft goodnight of hobbits who mean it, and somewhere down the narrow hall his even breathing had already begun.

Elric sat alone in the low, round room, the last stub of a candle guttering at his elbow. Before him, upon the oakwood table, rested the small black coffer, as though it had been waiting for this solitude.

For a long while he studied it without touching, his sharp eyes following the strange, silvered markings that crawled like frost along the lid. They were not Elvish, nor Dwarvish either, though echoes of both tongues seemed buried in their shape, like roots tangled beneath stone. And yet, the longer he looked, the less they seemed like writing at all.

He leaned closer, the soft smoke of his pipe curling faintly in the lamplight, and as his gaze traced the coiled sigils, an unease stirred beneath his ribs. There was a rhythm hidden there, almost — not letters, not words, but something older. Patterns repeating, rising and falling, like the faintest ghost of a song too ancient to name.

He drew a slow breath, and in that moment he fancied he heard something — or *felt* it — not with his ears but somewhere deeper, below thought, below memory. A thread of sound folded within silence. A harmony that was not his own.

Elric Bramblethorn closed his eyes, and in the dark behind them, it seemed the runes were still burning faintly, like embers adrift on black water.

Somewhere, far off, the Brandywine murmured under starlight, quiet and endless.

When he opened his eyes again, he whispered softly to himself, though the words were not meant for Marlo nor any in Middle-earth:

“The Music stirs...”

The candle gave its last, small flicker — then died, leaving only the hush of the smial, the faint rasp of Marlo’s dreaming breath, and the coffer sitting silent beneath the window that looked out toward the river.

Chapter Two

The Road to Bree

Marlo woke before the dawn, though the long hours of the night had left him restless and heavy-eyed. He had dreamed of the coffer again — or perhaps not dreamed, for the images had been sharp and strange. He saw wide halls beneath green hills, music like running water, and a high voice singing in a tongue he did not know, but which trembled through him like the pluck of harp-strings. When he rose and padded softly into the front room, he found Elric Bramblethorn seated cross-legged on the rug, the coffer before him and the last of a candle guttering at his side.

Elric looked up at him, his dark hair falling loose around a face that in the thin light seemed neither wholly hobbit nor wholly elvish, but something between.

“You were awake all night?” Marlo asked, rubbing at his eyes.

Elric smiled faintly, though his gaze lingered on the coffer. “Not all night, but enough. There is something hidden in its making. I cannot read the runes — they are not of the West, nor any craft of Rivendell, nor even the old dwarf-marks I’ve seen. But there is... pattern beneath the pattern, if you take my meaning.”

Marlo frowned and drew his dressing-gown tighter. “I take no such meaning at all.”

“Not in the letters themselves,” Elric said softly, tapping the lid with a long finger. “In the *music* they follow. I almost hear it when I close my eyes — faint as a remembered song. And I tell you, friend Marlo, such craft does not come from small folk like ours, nor from any Bree-ward tinker’s forge.”

Marlo hesitated, feeling again the faint Tookish restlessness he had known the day before, when Elric first arrived at the market. It tugged at him, quiet and insistent, like the pull of a far-off road.

“You think it’s valuable?” he asked at last.

Elric chuckled softly. “If it is not, then it hides its plainness behind deep sorcery. And if it is, Marlo Took, then there may be folk in Bree who will know its worth — or its danger.”

Marlo chewed the inside of his cheek, gazing at the little box as though it might suddenly reveal itself. Bree was three days’ journey by pony-cart, perhaps four if the weather turned, and Marlo had not been so far from Tookbank since his tweens. Yet the thought had rooted itself now, stubborn and alive.

“I suppose,” Marlo said slowly, “you mean to go there.”

Elric’s eyes lifted from the coffer, bright and intent. “I mean we should. There are traders in Bree with long memories, and lorekeepers who gather in the Prancing Pony — old men who know the remnants of every wandering tongue. If there is any place this coffer may be named, it is there.”

Marlo shifted uneasily and glanced towards the round window, where the pale hint of morning pressed against the glass. Outside, Tookbank still slept beneath low mists creeping up from the Brandywine. He thought of his garden, of his pipe, of the comfortable pattern of his days — and then of the soft, strange song in Elric’s voice, and the way the box seemed almost to hum when touched by candlelight.

“Well,” he said at last, drawing in a deep breath, “I suppose a Took would be shamed if he turned his back on a riddle like this.”

Elric smiled, but there was no triumph in it, only a quiet understanding. He set the coffer carefully back on the table and rose, stretching his shoulders.

“Then we leave with the rising of the sun,” he said simply.

By the time the sun crept low over the hills, Tookbank was stirring. A light wind teased the first blossoms from the orchard trees, and smoke rose thinly from round chimneys along the lane. The little market-square was alive with carts and ponies, the clatter of barrels, and the rattle of early trade. As Marlo stepped out into the crisp air, pack slung over one shoulder, he felt the curious eyes of neighbours upon him. Hobbits glanced from doorways and windows, some nodding, others whispering at the sight of the tall, half-elven stranger standing by the gate with a dark-green cloak drawn close.

Elric ignored them entirely, gazing instead toward the distant folds of the Green Hill Country, where the faint line of the road wound westward toward Stock and Bree beyond.

“You’re certain of this?” Marlo muttered as he joined him, tightening the straps on his pack.

“Only of the walking,” Elric replied, his lips curving faintly. “The rest — well, the road knows more than we do.”

Marlo stood upon his doorstep with a hand to his brow, squinting into the cool light as the smell of damp earth and sweet clover drifted up from the banks below. He had packed poorly — a lumpy satchel tied with twine — and even now seemed unsure whether he was off on a grand errand or making a great mistake. Beside him, Elric Bramblethorn was quiet and thoughtful, his dark hair curling damply where the mist had kissed it, and his long fingers idly turning the brass key of his pipe.

“Come,” said Elric quietly, without turning. “There is no wisdom in leaving such a thing untended. The coffer may be harmless — or not. Bree will have folk who know its making, if anyplace does.”

Marlo rubbed his eyes, staring past Elric’s shoulder at the pale wisping fog that drifted in bands along the valley. “Bree’s a long way, Elric. It’s no small stroll across the Green Hills, nor a matter of a day or two.”

“Aye,” said Elric, at last glancing back, his strange-grey eyes catching some pale light of their own. “But it is the safer road than leaving mystery untended upon your hearth. There are traders, lore-keepers... even wandering folk of my kin that pass that way. Someone, somewhere, will know these runes.”

Marlo hesitated — the deep, hobbit-sense of things clashing in him: the warm pull of home and the Tookish itch of danger. At last, he nodded. “Well, if Bree it is, we’d best make for the Brandywine Road. But I’ll not walk all that way on my feet, nor carry this thing across half the Shire like a pack-mule. We’ll take the cart to Stock Ferry. That’ll cut two days of tramping at least.”

By the time they stepped outside, the mists had begun to burn away, and Tookbank was waking gently, like an old hound stretching in the sun. Beyond Marlo’s smial, the low stone fences wore garlands of dew; smoke rose from little chimneys where breakfasts were underway; somewhere a cock crowed with cheerful complaint.

They crossed the green to where the small pony-cart stood waiting — a sturdy little trap run by Mr. Diggle Tunnely, who’d been ferrying folk between Tookbank and the river lanes for near on forty years. His brown pony, Mossy, pawed the grass lazily, the harness jingling faintly.

“Mornin’!” called Diggle, tipping his floppy felt hat with one hand while fussing with the reins. “Off t’ Stock, is it? Or further along the Ferry Lane?”

“To Stock,” said Marlo, adjusting the strap across his shoulder where the coffer sat wrapped in a thick cloth.

Diggle gave a low whistle. “Long way t’ haul so early. Best you settle yourselves quick, for Mossy don’t fancy waiting when she smells the oats waitin’ at Brandywine’s end.”

The cart was small but sturdy, its boards polished smooth from years of service, and a faint scent of hay clung to the worn cushions. They climbed aboard, Marlo settling beside Elric, who kept the coffer close upon his lap.

With a cluck of tongue and a soft snap of the reins, Diggle set them off. Mossy trotted gamely onto the narrow lane, and the cart creaked along at its steady, patient pace. The day grew warmer, the air soft and filled with the scents of damp earth and meadowflowers.

Hobbits went about their little morning doings as they passed — a washerwoman pegging linens upon a rope, two lads chasing a runaway hat down a slope, an old Gaffer trimming his rose-hedge

with exaggerated seriousness. And everywhere, Marlo caught the glances: quick, curious looks cast at Elric's tall frame and grey cloak. Whispers followed faintly, though no one spoke bold enough to ask.

Elric sat very still, his gaze resting somewhere far beyond the fields, but Marlo could sense his unease. The half-elf seemed not quite to belong in the slow hum of the Shire, as though some secret wind always moved around him while the air here lay still.

It was a long, drowsy ride. The cart rolled beneath little bowers of hawthorn and rowan, along hedge-bound paths where wild mint scented the air, and over stone bridges under which small, busy streams gurgled unseen. The sun climbed higher, throwing patches of gold upon the fields, and still the Brandywine's dark line did not yet show itself.

"Strange folk bound for Bree," Diggle said at last, as though unable to hold his tongue longer. "Don't see many o' that sort these days, no sir. Best be keeping your eyes open once you're out beyond Buckland — roads are busy with wandering folk since spring."

Elric gave him a small, unreadable smile. "We will keep them open," he said softly.

Marlo leaned back, pulling at his pipe, and said nothing. But the thought of Bree — of secrets locked within the coffer, of wandering roads and strange folk — worked its way beneath his skin, setting his Tookish heart to a quiet, restless beat.

The pony-cart rattled gently over the worn, sunken road, the soft thud of hooves muffled beneath the canopy of yellowing elm and oak. It was one of the little coaches that made its slow way from Tookbank to Stock and, from there, to the Brandywine ferry, carrying hobbits about their errands and visits, and sometimes, as in the case of Marlo and Elric, beyond.

The morning mist still clung low to the ditches, silvered and thin, and the damp air smelled of wild mint and damp earth. For a while, neither Marlo nor Elric spoke, each content to watch the rolling fields pass by — the green quilt of the Shire stitched together by low hedgerows and narrow paths.

"Never thought I'd be taking the east road again," Marlo said at last, shifting his pipe between his fingers. "My uncle always said the land about Bucklebury gets *too close* to queer folk and dealings. But then, I never thought I'd have a coffer like that either." He gave a quiet chuckle that sounded forced, more to reassure himself than anything else.

Elric did not reply at once. His gaze was on the far-off hills, where a faint shadow lingered longer than it ought to beneath the slow-moving clouds. At last, he said softly, "Sometimes things find us, Marlo, whether we seek them or no."

The cart swayed gently as it crested a low rise, and from there the view opened wide. To the north and south, little hamlets and farmsteads dotted the hills, their thatched roofs glinting faintly. But between them, the travellers saw something else — smoke, thin and black, rising from the far hedgerows.

Marlo frowned. "Chimney-fires, likely," he muttered. "Or... or burning leaves. Aye, that's all." But Elric said nothing, his hand tightening slightly on the worn edge of the cart.

A mile or so on, they passed through the outskirts of Whitfurrows, where a small gathering of hobbits stood muttering near the post lane. A cartwheel lay broken in the ditch, and a hay-barrow

tipped on its side. There was a tension in the air, the sort one could not quite name — voices too sharp, hands too quick.

“Bad lot from Overhill came down in the night,” an older hobbit called to the driver as they rolled by. “Threw stones and frightened the children. Fighting over market rights, they said. Never seen the like, not in these parts.”

The driver grunted, offered a vague “*Hmph!*”, and urged the pony on. Elric watched the scene over his shoulder until it dwindled from sight.

The road bent downhill after a time, drawing them closer to the Brandywine. The wide, slow river glimmered faintly in the distance, its surface pale beneath the wan sun. A soft breeze carried the scent of damp earth and green things, yet there was another smell too — faint, metallic, lingering beneath it, and Elric wrinkled his nose without meaning to.

As they neared Stock, the signs of quiet unease grew clearer. Near the edge of a barley field, two young hobbits were locked in a quarrel, voices raised and faces flushed red. A third tried vainly to pull them apart, calling something about “the missing nets” and “stolen ropes.” Tobas muttered under his breath and flicked the reins, hastening the pony’s pace, but Elric glanced back long after they’d passed.

“What’s gotten into folk, I wonder,” Marlo said, trying to sound casual but failing.

“It’s not just folk,” Elric murmured, half to himself. He thought of the scuffed earth, the broken stones, the strange rune-lines on the coffer and the faint, troubling shapes he’d glimpsed in them by candlelight. A restlessness was creeping into the quiet lands, he felt it — like distant thunder pressing against the hills.

By the time the roofs of Stock came into view, clustered around the slow bend of the river, the sense of strangeness had deepened into something heavier, though no one spoke of it. Ahead lay the ferry — and beyond it, the long road north and east, where answers might be found, if any were to be had.

Elric glanced sidelong at Marlo and lowered his voice. “By this time tomorrow, we’ll be on the road to Bree. And I’ve a feeling, Marlo, that whatever we find there will bind us tighter to this coffer than either of us yet understands.”

The cart slowed as they entered the village, hooves clopping over cobbles slick with damp. A tavern’s warm glow spilled into the road: The Golden Perch, its timbered front bright with carved lintels and curling vinework. A painted board swung lazily in the night breeze, its sign of a foaming tankard half-worn by rain and years. From within came bursts of laughter, the thump of mugs on tables, and the low murmur of many voices—but it was not the usual lilting cheer one expected of hobbits at their ale. There was a sharper edge, something fretful beneath the laughter.

The driver drew the cart up beside the tavern and Marlo glanced at Elric.

“Best stretch our legs a bit,” he said softly. “Stock’s a talkative place, and if there’s news on the roads, it’ll be heard here first.”

Inside, the Golden Perch was thick with warmth and smoke, the air scented with malt and oakwood. Clusters of hobbits sat at crowded benches, tankards in hand, their voices dropping low whenever strangers passed. The fire popped and hissed in the great hearth, and shadows played long across the

rafters overhead. Elric and Marlo took a place near the back, beneath a low beam darkened by years of pipe smoke, and ordered a small supper with mugs of dark ale.

As they ate, Elric let his keen half-elvish ears wander among the mutterings around them. Bits of whispers drifted by, half-caught through the hum of the room:

“—sheep went missing, whole flock, not a sign left but the ground trampled hard—”

“—and down by Deephallow, they say... lights in the marshes, colours no lantern ever burned—”

“...strangers on the Greenway... Men, tall as beeches and none too friendly by the sound...”

Marlo leaned in, lowering his voice.

“Something’s stirring, sure enough. Always said when things go bad in the Eastfarthing, it blows through here first. Bree-folk bringing tales again, no doubt, making the ale stronger than it is.”

But Elric was not so sure. His gaze slid to the small cloth-wrapped coffer resting on the bench beside him. Even here, in the tavern’s snug warmth, it seemed to hold a hush about it, as though it belonged to deeper places than this well-lit hall.

Near the door, an old hobbit with silvered curls leaned upon a knotted walking-stick, telling some tale to three wide-eyed farmers. His voice was cracked but earnest:

“...seen with my own eyes, I tell ye. Black shapes slipping through the willows, quiet as ghosts, and when I called out, they vanished. Not like foxes, no... walking like Men they were, but quicker, sliding over the earth without sound.”

A ripple of unease passed through the benches nearby. One or two laughed it off, though uneasily, while others muttered that old Nibs Tunnely had been too deep in his cups again.

Elric leaned close to Marlo.

“We should move on quickly,” he said under his breath. “There’s a pattern in this—whispers and half-tales from all across the Shire. It could be nothing, but...” He hesitated, his hand brushing the edge of the cloth around the coffer. “Or it could be something drawn awake.”

Marlo’s fingers tightened unconsciously around the stem of his pipe as he followed Elric’s gaze across the dim-lit common room. The Golden Perch was quieter than he’d ever known it, though a good dozen hobbits sat hunched at the tables, mugs of pale ale sweating in their hands. The hush inside was not the warmth of tired travellers but something heavier—like rainclouds gathering behind closed shutters. Snatches of talk rose and fell: *cattle gone missing... a child’s dream of black trees marching... queer lights seen over the mounds by Whitfurrows*. Each tale was half-spoken, ending in mutters and the soft scrape of chairs as voices leaned closer to one another.

Elric’s brow was furrowed, his eyes following each fragment of speech like a hound scenting faint traces in the air. Marlo glanced at him and muttered low, “Don’t start pulling at loose threads, lad, else you’ll find yourself tangled up before supper.”

But Elric didn’t answer. His gaze had drifted toward a small table near the back wall, where three hobbits sat whispering, their tankards untouched. One, a weathered fellow in a brown waistcoat, was tracing something in spilled ale with his fingertip: a crude circle with a jagged line cleaving it in two. When he noticed Elric watching, he covered it swiftly with his palm and bent his head.

At length, Elric leaned close to Marlo. “They’ve seen something,” he whispered. “Not just here. All over, by the sound of it. Small signs, perhaps... but signs nonetheless.”

Marlo shifted uncomfortably. “Stock’s always been full o’ rumourmongers. Always chasing bogeymen and conjured shadows. You’ll see tomorrow—when the sun’s up, this will all seem thinner than morning mist.” He puffed at his pipe, though the smoke seemed to hang uneasily in the low light, as though reluctant to rise.

Just then, the innkeeper—a round-cheeked hobbit named Bando Goodbody—came bustling past with a tray of foaming mugs. Marlo caught his sleeve.

“Bando,” he said in a low voice, “what’s put everyone in such a hush tonight? Feels like the whole room’s listening for footsteps.”

Bando hesitated, glanced about the room, and leaned in close enough that his breath smelled faintly of malt.

“It’s talk from east o’ the river,” he said, almost beneath his breath. “Three farms near Deephollow, gone near-quiet as tombs. Smoke still in the chimneys, food on the tables, beds turned down neat—but no sign o’ the folk that lived there. Not a footprint nor a wagon track leadin’ away. Vanished, they have.”

Marlo felt a coldness under his ribs. Elric said nothing, though his hand crept to the leather strap of the coffer, checking it without looking down.

“Some say it’s foxes,” Bando went on, his voice low but quick. “Others mutter about Old Things stirring under the hills, things we oughtn’t to name this side of Yule. But it’s not just Deephollow, see—talk’s the same out Bywater way, and there’s been queer noises in the Woody End at night.”

Bando straightened as a call came from the far end of the room, forced a cheerful smile, and bustled away.

For a long moment neither Elric nor Marlo spoke. Somewhere beyond the shuttered windows came the faint sound of frogs by the riverbank, their croaking thin against the heavy stillness.

At last Elric leaned forward, his voice little more than a breath:

“Marlo... this isn’t rumour. This is a net tightening, strand by strand.”

Marlo drew slow on his pipe and exhaled, watching the smoke curl toward the low rafters. “Aye,” he said quietly. “Then best we get across the river come dawn.”

The morning broke soft and pale over Stock, a cool mist drifting up from the reeds along the Brandywine, silvering the grass and leaving the small thatched roofs beaded with dew. The village was only just stirring, with a few early risers carrying pails of water or leading donkeys down towards the shallows, their voices muffled and subdued.

Elric was already awake, seated cross-legged on the edge of the low bed in the tiny room above the tavern, the coffer resting before him on the blanket. The single candle on the sill burned low, casting wavering shadows over the strange runes carved into the wood. He had been studying them for much of the night, though his weary eyes had yielded no better understanding.

Marlo stirred beneath the quilt, grumbling as he rolled over. “Elric,” he muttered sleepily, “if you’ve sat up whispering at that box one more hour, you’ll start talking in riddles yourself.”

Elric did not look up, his long fingers tracing the grooves as if trying to summon some memory from deep time. “It isn’t Elvish,” he murmured, almost to himself. “Nor Dwarvish either, I’d

wager... but there's a pattern beneath it. Something older than the Shire, older than the Kings even. There's... *music* in it, if you listen closely."

Marlo sat up, rubbing his eyes and yawning. "Music? I hear nothing but the crowing of that blasted cockerel next door." He stretched, pulling on his waistcoat with sluggish hands. "Come on now, master Elf-man, we've a cart to catch, and I want a good seat before the other hobbits pack it full."

Elric finally sighed, pulling a plain linen cloth over the coffer and slipping it into his satchel. "Aye, perhaps Bree will have someone wiser than I. But mark me, Marlo—this is no common trinket. I've handled relics from Arnor itself, and none set my hair on end as this does."

They descended to the common room of the tavern, which smelled of pipeweed, damp wool, and last night's ale. The innkeeper's wife was setting out oatcakes and honey for the few early customers, while two ferrymen sat hunched at the far table, whispering fiercely. Snatches of their talk carried across the room:

"...and another fight by the Hay Gate, can you believe it? All over missing sheep, they say, but Harl says it wasn't wolves at all. Not with the hoofprints he saw..."

"...hoofprints? Out near Deephallow too, aye. Only no horse of the Shire walks on cloven feet..."

Marlo's brows furrowed, but he stayed quiet as they ate their breakfast. By the time the plates were cleared, the pony-cart was readying outside—an old service road cart painted green, meant for ferrying hobbits between Stock the Brandywine Bridge.

The morning air was cool and damp as they set off. The cart rattled gently along the packed dirt lane, its two ponies plodding with steady patience while a handful of hobbits dozed beneath cloaks and shawls. Elric sat beside Marlo near the front, leaning slightly on the worn rail, his hood drawn low.

"Strange words in the tavern," Elric said at last, watching the pale mist rise from the ditches.

Marlo nodded, puffing on his short-stemmed pipe. "Aye, and I don't like the sound of it. Cloven prints, missing sheep, tempers running high. My Uncle Baldo once said that when good folk start muttering about things best left unsaid, it's time to mind your steps."

Elric glanced at him, a faint smile tugging at the corner of his lips. "Your uncle sounds a wise hobbit."

"He once tried to trap a troll with nothing but a sack of mushrooms and a spade," Marlo replied drily. "But aye, he knew when trouble was brewing."

The cart crested a low rise, and there, where the lane dipped into the gentle folds of meadowland before the Brandywine Bridge, two young hobbits stood at the roadside, waving for the cart to slow. One was sturdy, broad-shouldered, and freckled, his round face shaded by a battered cap; the other was slighter, wiry, with quick, keen eyes that missed nothing.

The driver reined in the ponies, muttering, "Gamgie lads, by the look of it," and the two clambered aboard, tossing polite greetings as they settled near the back.

Marlo leaned close to Elric, lowering his voice. "That's young Holman Gamgie, Hamfast's cousin, if I'm not mistaken, and with him Briffo Brandybuck—an adventurous sort, that one. If anyone's got tales of odd doings in these parts, it'll be those two."

Elric's eyes brightened slightly. "Then perhaps we'll hear more than whispers, if they're willing to speak."

The cart jolted back into motion, rolling slowly towards the bridge and the wide road beyond, while the mists of the riverlands began to thin and the first true warmth of the sun touched the fields.

"And I see Briffo Brandybuck has found his way this far east," Elric said, inclining his head with the slightest of smiles.

"Found it, aye," Briffo replied lightly, "though it weren't for lack o' wandering. I've come down from Bucklebury this morning with Holman here, for there's talk along the Marish that the folk o' Stock keep a steadier ale than we get along the river. That, and—" He hesitated, glancing sidelong at Elric, lowering his voice. "—there's been queer murmurings of late. Things not quite right, y'know. Best to keep ears open."

Elric exchanged a look with Marlo, though he said nothing, his hand resting unconsciously on the strap of his pack where the small coffer lay concealed.

The four of them walked on together, their breath pale in the cold air. Ahead, the damp road dipped slightly towards the Brandywine, where the sound of water came soft and steady through the fog.

Briffo was the first to speak again. "Strange days, Marlo. Stranger than any I've seen since I was a lad."

Elric listened, his dark brows drawn. At last he spoke quietly, his voice low but steady:

"It seems to me, friends, that these tidings are of a piece. Small signs, perhaps, but together they weave a pattern—a shadow passing over the Shire. I would not ignore it."

Marlo glanced sidelong at him, uneasy but trusting. "All the more reason we ought to be quick about Bree, then. Best to know what we're carrying, before the whispers become more than whispers."

As they reached the bridge itself, the fog thickened. It coiled about the timbers and stone arches, brushing against the ponies' flanks like the breath of some unseen thing. The world beyond the bridge was hazy and grey; the opposite bank disappeared into a soft, shifting wall of vapour. The sound of the river beneath, usually a gentle gurgle and rush, now seemed deeper, heavier, and somehow more alive, like the river itself was holding its breath.

Holman Gamgie shivered and pulled his cloak tighter. "By the Gaffer's beard," he muttered, "it's cold and damp enough to seep into your bones."

Briffo Brandybuck leaned over the side of the bridge, peering into the grey distance. "Aye," he said quietly, "and there's something... odd about this fog. Feels wrong, somehow. As if it's not just water and air, but something waiting, listening."

Marlo glanced at Elric, whose dark eyes seemed to pierce the mist. "You feel it too, don't you?" he asked, voice low.

Elric nodded, his fingers brushing absentmindedly along the strap of his pack where the coffer lay. "This fog is not ordinary," he said softly. "There is an edge to it, a presence. It carries whispers—faint, and yet old, older than any man or hobbit living."

The ponies shifted nervously beneath them, stamping their hooves and twitching their ears. Somewhere in the mist, a bird called—a sharp, single note that echoed strangely across the water. The sound carried, yet did not seem to originate from anywhere, and it left a hollow silence in its wake.

Holman swallowed, looking uneasily at Briffo. “I don’t like this,” he admitted. “It’s as if the river’s hiding secrets we’re not meant to see.”

Elric’s lips tightened. “Perhaps. Or perhaps it is simply revealing them slowly, testing our attention. The coffer, the whispers from Stock, the strange tracks along the way... it gathers here, at the edge of the Shire, where the world grows wider, older, and stranger.”

Marlo tightened his grip on the cart’s side. “Let’s just get across, then,” he said firmly, though even he felt the chill creeping up his spine. “Soon as we’re over, we can see the road to Bree and leave this damp, ghostly fog behind.”

But the fog clung to them still, swirling around the bridge’s rails and the ponies’ legs, carrying with it that subtle, pervasive sense that something watched, waited, and measured their passing. And as they slowly crossed the Brandywine, the river beneath seemed darker than usual, whispering along its currents in a language older than any hobbit’s memory.

Holman shivered again. “I’d swear the river spoke tonight,” he muttered.

Briffo only nodded, and Elric remained silent, his gaze fixed on the grey horizon where the road to Bree vanished into the fog. And for the first time, all four felt, deep within, that the world beyond the Shire was more than they had ever known—strange, restless, and quietly awakening.

The cart rumbled slowly onto the far bank of the Brandywine, the fog thinning just enough to reveal the gentle slopes and hedgerows of the Eastfarthing beyond. The river hissed and foamed against the pilings of the bridge as though reluctant to let them go, and a cold wind lifted off the water, carrying a scent of damp reeds and something faintly metallic.

Elric helped Marlo down first, then gestured for Holman and Briffo to follow. The four of them fell into the slow, familiar rhythm of hobbit travel: steady steps on the soft earth, occasional pauses to adjust packs or smooth ponies’ harnesses, and quiet murmurs exchanged under the low, pale light of morning.

“Brandywine’s wider than I’d thought,” Holman remarked, his voice low, as if speaking too loudly might wake something in the mist. “And the fog... it’s not quite gone. I can still feel it curling over the fields, almost like fingers brushing the grass.”

Briffo shivered and tugged his cap lower over his ears. “Aye. The wind brings more than chill, I think. There’s talk down near the ferry of strange folk wandering the marshes at night. Old Togo says he saw figures pale as bone, moving without a sound.”

Marlo frowned. “Figures or shadows?” he asked, glancing at Elric.

Elric’s dark eyes narrowed. “Perhaps both,” he said softly. “Shadows often take shape when the mind is half alert, half uneasy. But the river and the fog do not lie entirely. Keep watch; keep steady. We must reach Bree before evening, and with care.”

The road beyond the Brandywine was narrow and winding, flanked by low hedges and ditches where small flowers and reeds pushed through the damp soil. Every so often, they passed a

farmstead, the chimneys sending thin trails of smoke into the grey air. Doors were shuttered and windows closed, and they caught the occasional glance of a wary farmer, or a dog that barked sharply before retreating behind its gate.

Marlo thought about the coffer beneath Elric's cloak, and how its silent presence seemed to thrum faintly against the quiet of the morning. Even the ponies seemed attuned to it, stepping cautiously over stones and ruts.

Holman broke the silence at last. "Do you think the folk in Bree will know what to make of it?" he asked, glancing at Elric.

"I hope so," Elric replied, his voice calm but carrying a weight that made the hobbits uneasy. "There are those there who still remember the old ways, the old signs. If the coffer is as old as I suspect, Bree is the nearest place where someone might understand its markings—or, at the very least, its danger."

The cart creaked on, moving slowly over the soft earth. A distant crow called from a tree beyond the hedge, and the sound seemed sharper than usual, cutting through the morning hush. The four hobbits exchanged glances, each silently aware that something watched beyond the lane, in the hedgerows or perhaps beyond them.

And so they walked, step by careful step, the road unfurling before them, carrying them toward Bree and the faint promise of knowledge—and peril—waiting at the end of the misty Eastfarthing lanes.

The road bent eastward, and before them the line of the Old Forest came into sight—a dark and tangled edge of ancient trees whose tops swayed faintly though no wind touched the grass at their feet. The Brandywine behind them was now hidden by the gentle folds of land, and the four hobbits and Elric walked in single file along the rutted path. A pale sun was struggling to break through the thin, high clouds, casting long threads of silver across the fields.

Elric slowed his pace, his keen eyes fixed upon the looming treeline. "There," he said softly, as though reluctant to raise his voice in that place. He lifted a long hand and pointed. "The Old Forest. Few now pass beneath those boughs, though it was not always so. My people have long spoken of its deep roots and the strange voices that stir within. Some say the trees remember a time before hobbits first tilled these fields, and that they remember it not kindly."

Holman Gamgie, walking just behind him, gave a doubtful snort and adjusted his pack straps. "Begging your pardon, Mr. Elric, but that's just fireside talk. There's queer rustlings, aye, and Tom Cotton's uncle swears blind he once saw branches moving when there weren't no wind—but trees don't *think*, not proper-like."

Briffo Brandybuck was less certain, though he tried to sound unconcerned. "Maybe they don't think," he said, chewing thoughtfully on a stalk of grass, "but they've been standing there a mighty long while, and long-lived things often have secrets. My gran used to say you shouldn't linger too near their edge come dusk, lest you find the shadows walking behind you."

Marlo shivered and drew his cloak tighter, though the day was not cold. "I don't like it," he muttered. "Not the mist this morning, nor the way the air feels now. It's as though the Shire itself has grown... watchful."

Elric said nothing for a time, his dark eyes distant as though he listened to something beyond their hearing. At last, he murmured, “It is not just the Shire, Marlo. All lands are waking from long slumbers. Things that slept beneath stone and soil are stirring. The signs are faint, but they are there, if one knows how to look.”

Holman frowned uneasily. “That sounds right queer, that does. Stirring things don’t often bring good news. But Bree’s not far, and Bree-folk’ll know if trouble’s brewing—they always hear whispers before the rest of us.”

“Yes,” Elric said, his gaze still fixed on the shadowed fringe of the Old Forest. “In Bree, perhaps, there will be answers. Or at least more questions to trouble our sleep.”

The path wound on, narrowing as it skirted the deep shadows of the Old Forest. Though the morning had begun bright enough when they crossed the Brandywine, the sun now stood veiled behind a pale shroud of high cloud, and the air hung still and cool, muffled beneath a heavy quiet.

Marlo pulled his cloak tighter about his shoulders and glanced sidelong into the tangle of trees that rose beyond the low embankment, their limbs knotted like clenched fists. The leaves, though touched faintly with early autumn’s turn, held a dull, waxen sheen, as though they had drunk too much shade.

“Elric,” he murmured, breaking a long silence. “This road’s always had a queer feel to it, but today it’s worse than I remember.”

Elric walked a little ahead, his long strides untroubled by the uneven road. He carried the coffer slung across his back, well-wrapped in his pack, though his hand rested near it, often and unconsciously, as if to reassure himself it was still there. At Marlo’s words, he slowed and gestured to the forest’s dark edge.

“That’s the Old Forest,” he said, his voice low, as though reluctant to disturb the hush. “There’s queer tales enough about it to fill a dozen evenings by the hearth. Trees older than hobbits or even the first men to walk the Downs. Folk say they remember... remember things best forgotten. That they’ve long memories of axes and fires and lost paths.”

Holman Gamgie, walking just behind them, gave a little snort and shifted the straps of his pack. “And some folk say cows fly if you feed ‘em enough mushrooms,” he muttered, though his voice carried no great conviction. He peered over Marlo’s shoulder at the tangled woods and frowned. “Still... my dad used to warn me not to wander too close. Said there’s roots in there deeper than any story.”

Briffo Brandybuck, trotting along cheerfully despite the mood, adjusted the tilt of his feathered cap and grinned. “Ah, roots or no roots, it’s the riverfolk who keep the best tales about this place. My uncle swore blind that he once saw lights, blue as starlight, dancing up from the earth beneath them trees.” He twirled a finger in the air for effect. “Said he heard music, too, though no pipe nor fiddle was playing.”

No one replied. The wind had died to nothing, and in its absence, a faint rustling drifted out from the treeline — soft at first, but persistent, as though many dry leaves were stirring without breeze enough to move them.

Marlo slowed his pace. “Hear that?” he whispered.

They all halted, listening. The sound came and went, like breath drawn and held beneath the earth, then loosed again in shallow sighs. There was no movement in the trees, and yet the rustling seemed to travel — circling, almost — before melting back into silence.

Elric's gaze lingered on the forest's edge, but his face betrayed little. "Best keep to the road," he said at last, his voice low and steady. "We've miles yet to Bree, and night'll find us sooner than we'd like if we dawdle here."

As they walked on, Briffo glanced behind him once or twice, his usual levity subdued. Holman kept closer to Marlo than before, muttering something under his breath about "weather changing on a whim."

But Elric remained silent, his thoughts somewhere deep, far from the road and the forest's brooding edge — though once, when the rustling rose faintly again, his hand drifted unconsciously towards the hidden coffer on his back, as though the shapes carved upon it had begun to stir in his memory.

And behind them, though none turned to see, a crow lifted from the treeline, black as pitch, wheeling once before vanishing into the mist above.

The lane bent low beneath the rise of the land, and as they walked on, the edges of the **Old Forest** began to creep nearer on their right-hand side. The trees stood close and dark, leaning forward as though listening, their summer leaves whispering faintly though there was hardly any wind. Here and there, roots knuckled through the damp earth, twisted and swollen, forcing the little company to step carefully as the path grew uneven.

Elric had grown quiet again, his sharp grey eyes following the shadows between the boles. Briffo, for his part, was still humming a half-forgotten walking-song under his breath until Elric raised a hand for silence.

"Do you hear that?" he murmured.

The others strained their ears. At first there was nothing but the faint stirring of leaves and the occasional creak of an old bough. But then Marlo caught it too: a soft rustling, low and steady, somewhere deeper in the trees — as though something large was passing unseen among the trunks.

"Badgers, most like," Holman whispered, though his voice lacked conviction.

Before Elric could answer, Briffo stopped short and pointed. "Look — there, just beyond the slope!"

Far off between the trunks, no more than a brief flicker, they saw it: a tiny, pale light swaying gently, as though held in someone's hand. It glimmered once, twice, then was gone, swallowed again by the shadows.

Chapter Three: The Old Forest

"A lantern," Marlo breathed, frowning. "Hobbit-made, by the look — pale glass and brass fittings. But what would anyone be doing out there at this hour?"

No one replied. The Old Forest was not the sort of place hobbits wandered lightly — not at dusk, and certainly not alone. The four of them stood still, straining their eyes, but the glow did not return.

The rustling seemed to have faded too. For a long moment there was only the quiet weight of the forest, pressing in, thick with the smell of damp earth and fern. Somewhere, far off, a branch cracked sharply — a sound like a whipcrack carried on the still air.

Elric adjusted the strap of the bow across his shoulder but said nothing. His jaw was set, his ears half-cocked, though he kept them moving along the path.

“Maybe it was nothing,” Briffo offered, though his voice was thin. “Just a firefly caught in the leaves.”

Elric gave him a brief, unreadable look. “Fireflies don’t carry brass fittings,” he said softly.

The four hobbits went on a little while longer, keeping to the rutted road that curved like a pale ribbon along the skirts of the Old Forest. The pale sun was already slanting low, painting the tops of the tangled boughs with a coppery sheen, while beneath them the shadows lay thick and green-black.

It was Marlo who first saw it. He stopped short, blinking, and raised a hand.

“Look there,” he said, pointing slightly off the road, towards the wall of twisted undergrowth. “D’you see that? A light.”

The others crowded in beside him, peering through the bramble and oak-rooted gloom. There, perhaps twenty yards within the tangled eaves of the forest, hung a lantern — a small, round-bellied thing of beaten copper and glass panes, faintly greenish in the dimness. It swayed gently, though there was no wind in the trees, and its light gave off an oddly pale shimmer, like moonlight trapped in water.

Holman Gamgee frowned, hitching up his braces. “Well, that’s strange,” he muttered. “A hobbit lantern, sure as my name’s Holman, but what’s it doin’ in there? No one sets foot past these roots ‘cept woodcutters or folk with more guts than sense.”

Elric’s grey eyes narrowed. He said nothing, but there was a stiffness about his shoulders, as if something in him had gone tense.

Briffo Brandybuck was less cautious. He stepped forward, craning his neck. “It looks like a Brandy Hall make, that does — same copperwork, same glass cuts. My uncle’s smiths turn out the very image of it. Maybe someone’s misplaced it?”

“Misplaced it twenty yards deep into the Old Forest, and still lit?” Elric asked quietly, his voice low but carrying. “And hung, no less?”

Marlo, ever the impulsive one, suddenly gave a sharp laugh. “Well, I’ll find out who misplaced it then!”

Before anyone could catch his sleeve, he was off the path, scrambling down the low bank, his furry feet sending up little puffs of dry leaf-litter.

“Marlo! Come back!” Briffo called, half-whispering, half-hissing, glancing nervously at the shifting shadows beneath the trees.

The four of them moved cautiously now, the faint trace of the path beneath their feet guiding them, though the darkness pressed close and the trees loomed like silent watchers. The lantern had

vanished again, swallowed somewhere deeper in the tangle, leaving only the dim gleam of starlight through the upper canopy. Every snapping twig and rustling leaf set their hearts hammering.

“Elric,” Marlo whispered, “I don’t like this. I... I wish we were back on the road.”

Elric did not answer, his bow held loosely in one hand, ready, though the others could barely see it in the gloom. His eyes flicked from shadow to shadow, pale and unblinking, as if he were reading the forest itself.

Suddenly, Holman stumbled over something in the undergrowth with a muffled cry. Briffo lunged to catch him, but Marlo, hurrying too close behind, tripped over the same dark shape.

They all landed in a heap, the damp forest floor cold beneath them. Marlo’s breath caught as he looked down. A hand, pale and still, lay twisted upon the leaf-litter. The face was turned partially away, yet even so the wide eyes, dull and lifeless, were unmistakable.

A hobbit.

A dead hobbit, fallen where no living hobbit should have been.

Holman scrambled back, muttering prayers under his breath, while Briffo pressed a hand to his mouth, eyes wide with disbelief. Elric knelt for a moment, examining the form from the shadows, his hand never straying far from his bow.

“By the Valar,” he murmured softly, “this is no simple accident. Whoever—or whatever—brought them here, it was deliberate.”

The forest seemed to close in, the hush now heavy with menace. Somewhere beyond them, leaves rustled as if something moved too smoothly, too silently. The lantern, once a strange lure, now seemed a distant memory; here, in this dark pocket of twisted roots and shadow, the danger was closer, and far more immediate.

Marlo swallowed hard, a shiver running down his spine. “We should... we should go back,” he said, voice trembling.

Elric rose. “No,” he said quietly, but firmly. “We stay together. We move, yes, but we do not scatter. Keep close. Keep silent.”

The forest had grown darker as they stumbled along the faint path, roots and fallen leaves clutching at their boots. Each rustle in the undergrowth made them freeze; every shadow seemed to flicker with movement. Holman Gamgee whispered a prayer under his breath, and Briffo Brandybuck’s hand trembled as he gripped Marlo’s sleeve.

Then came a sound that made all four of them halt: a low, wet snarl, emanating from somewhere just beyond the edge of sight. The noise was alive, deliberate, and carried with it a hunger that chilled the marrow. The hobbits pressed close together, hearts hammering.

Something shifted in the gloom — a shape, low to the ground at first, then rising, coiling forward like smoke made solid. Two gleaming yellow eyes appeared, reflecting what little light there was. A snarl tore from the shadow, wet and savage, and a beast the size of a pony burst from the undergrowth, its fur matted and black, claws sinking into the soft earth.

Marlo stumbled backward, tripping over roots, and a scream caught in his throat. Holman and Briffo froze, paralyzed with shock, as the creature advanced with unnatural speed.

In that moment, Elric moved. No one had noticed him draw a bow; his hands seemed to move of their own accord. The pale wood gleamed faintly in the half-light as he drew back the string, an arrow appearing as if conjured from the shadows. The bow hummed softly, a note almost musical, vibrating with unseen tension.

“Stay close!” Elric’s voice was quiet, commanding, yet it carried over the rustle of leaves.

The warg lunged, and the arrow sang through the air, striking deep. The creature yelped, staggered, but it was fast, its momentum carrying it closer. Another arrow followed, and then the forest erupted into a cacophony of snapping branches and growls as the beast fell with a heavy thud, shaking the leaves and undergrowth around them.

Marlo and the others stared, wide-eyed, hearts still pounding. The forest seemed to exhale, but the silence that followed was thick with a lingering menace, as though the dark itself were aware that they had trespassed.

Elric lowered the bow slowly, every movement deliberate, his eyes scanning the shadows. “The forest is not empty,” he murmured. “We move. Quietly. Together.”

The hobbits obeyed, stepping carefully over the fallen creature, the forest around them feeling alive in a new, sinister way. And somewhere deep in the shadows, beyond the reach of lantern or starlight, unseen eyes seemed to watch their every move.

Elric’s voice was low but firm, carrying easily over the ragged breaths of the hobbits.

“Back to the path,” he said. His eyes, pale and unyielding, never left the dark tangle of trees ahead. “Keep close, and move quickly.”

Holman and Briffo did not need telling twice. They scrambled to their feet, shoving past roots and loose earth, and ran toward the faint ribbon of trail that still threaded through the forest. Marlo followed more slowly, his mind heavy, his stomach knotted. Even as his legs carried him forward, he could not shake the image of the fallen hobbit, slumped among the leaves, hand still clutching the small coffer.

A dead hobbit, Marlo thought, the words turning over in his mind like stones in a stream. And this... this is strange times indeed.

Elric moved differently, almost gliding, facing the deeper forest as he led the way. The bow was still in his hand, loose but ready, his figure a pale sentinel against the dark. The forest pressed close, the shadows lengthening as if to follow them, but the path offered some small comfort: a ribbon of safety amid the dark, a guide to lead them out of the tangle.

Marlo’s eyes flicked back once, drawn irresistibly to the spot where the hobbit had fallen. The coffer lay there, small and still, untouched by the chaos that had passed through the trees. For a moment, Marlo imagined it opening of its own accord, spilling strange light into the gloom. But he forced his gaze forward, listening to the quiet shuffle of leaves behind him, the muted thump of Elric’s steps leading them back.

The forest gave way at last to the pale, filtered light of the road, though the trees still leaned close, whispering as the wind stirred. The four of them walked cautiously, their feet pressing into the soft dirt path, eyes darting to the shadows that still clung to the undergrowth.

“The hobbit,” Marlo said at last, voice tight, “still lying there... clutching that box. I’ve never seen anything like it.”

Holman shivered. “And that creature... a warg, here in the West! The Rangers must have missed it.”

Elric’s jaw tightened. His bow was slung across his back now, but his hand remained poised near it, as though he could draw again in an instant. “A warg should not be here,” he said slowly. “The lands are watched, yes — but clearly something has gone unseen. Strange times, indeed. Very strange times.”

Briffo muttered something under his breath about hobbits never seeing such things and never wanting to, and Marlo only nodded, still thinking of the fallen hobbit, still thinking of the coffer.

A rustle, sudden and sharp, came from the trees on their right. The leaves shook violently, and the ground seemed to vibrate with the thud of heavy paws.

“—Elric!” Marlo shouted. From the gloom, a second warg surged into the road, larger and fiercer than the first, teeth bared, eyes glowing yellow with malice.

Elric moved with a grace that seemed almost unnatural. His hand flew to his back, drawing the bow in one fluid motion. The arrow settled, fletched feathers catching the light of the early morning.

The warg lunged. Elric’s string sang; the arrow flew true. The creature yelped, staggering as it struck, but its momentum carried it forward, jaws snapping. Another arrow followed almost immediately, and the beast crashed into the side of the road, shaking the earth beneath it.

The hobbits fell back instinctively, hearts hammering, but Elric did not move from his stance. His eyes swept the forest, pale and unyielding, still alert for further movement.

Marlo swallowed, voice caught. “I... I didn’t think such creatures could come so far west... not here.”

Elric’s hand rested on his bow now, tension slowly easing but eyes still sharp. “The West is not as safe as it once was. The Rangers may guard the borders, yes, but strange things slip through, and dark tidings travel quietly.”

Holman and Briffo exchanged uneasy glances. The forest seemed to breathe around them, the mist lingering like a warning. The path ahead, however, remained clear — but none of them could shake the sense that something deeper, older, and more dangerous watched from the shadows, waiting for its chance.

The road widened as they pressed onward, the trees thinning at the edges until the soft green fields of the Brandywine meadows began to spread out before them. The mist still clung to the low hollows, curling around the bases of old oaks, but the immediate terror of the forest had passed, leaving only a quiet unease in its place.

Marlo kept his eyes fixed on the path, but his thoughts were tangled with what had occurred. “I still cannot believe... a hobbit, like that, and... and the coffer,” he murmured. “Strange times indeed.”

Holman shook his head. “I never thought I’d see a warg, not here. Not west of the old forests. Rangers must have missed it somehow.”

Briffo scowled, kicking at a loose stone. “Missed it? Or are they letting things slip through? You know, for... reasons beyond our ken.”

Elric walked slightly ahead of them, bow now slung at his back. He kept glancing to the sides, eyes pale in the morning light, mind clearly working over every sound and movement. “Perhaps,” he said quietly, “but there is more to this than a stray beast or a misstep in vigilance. Something stirs. Small things first — then larger. One cannot ignore signs like these.”

Marlo swallowed. “Do you mean the forest itself?”

Elric considered him, lips pressed into a thin line. “Yes... the rustling, the shapes, the air. Even the animals are uneasy. Something moves beneath, unseen, and it affects all things above.”

Holman muttered again, nervously. “I only hope it stays unseen, then. I’m a simple hobbit. Simple roads and fields are enough for me.”

Briffo chuckled, though faintly, not entirely at ease. “And yet we seem to have a knack for stumbling into the unusual.”

Marlo’s thoughts drifted again to the coffer in his pack. *Perhaps it has drawn this strange weight upon us*, he wondered, fingers brushing the leather strap. “And the hobbit we found... it was clutching it still. Why, I do not know. What did it feel, what did it understand?”

Elric’s gaze remained on the path. “Some things are older than our understanding, younger than our memory. Some things wait, quietly, for their moment. All we can do is be ready, and move with care.”

The road wound steadily upward, the Brandywine River now glimpsed far below, its waters glinting faintly in the morning sun. The mist had thinned, yet a chill lingered in the hollows, and the air smelled of damp earth and distant smoke. The hills rolled gently around them, the fields divided by neat hedgerows, the occasional cottage smoke curling lazily into the sky.

“Bree lies just beyond these hills,” Elric said softly, his gaze sweeping the horizon. “We will find inns, traders, and answers — perhaps even someone who can speak to the matter of the coffer.”

Marlo adjusted the pack on his back, feeling its familiar weight. “It will be good to see strangers, and not just the forest shadows,” he murmured. “Though I cannot rid my mind of that poor hobbit, or the forest’s strangeness.”

Holman and Briffo exchanged glances. “I dare say,” Holman said, “that the Shire does not prepare one for such... happenings. One expects quiet, and only quiet.”

The road dipped into a gentle hollow, and the first signs of Bree emerged — smoke curling higher, the outline of timbered buildings beyond low hedges. The distant murmur of human voices reached them, carried faintly over the hills, mingling with the calls of birds and the rustle of leaves.

Elric’s hand rested lightly on the bow slung across his back, the strap creaking faintly as he adjusted his stride. “Keep watch. Even near towns, one cannot wholly forget the wild. Strange things linger, even where men dwell.”

Marlo looked at him curiously. “Are the people of Bree aware of the... oddities beyond their walls?”

“They sense, yes,” Elric said, eyes still forward. “But most ignore what cannot touch them directly. That is their choice. We have none. Not with what we carry.”

The four of them continued slowly down the slope, the familiar hum of civilization growing louder, yet carrying with it an undercurrent of unease. For all the roads, for all the cottages and fields, the shadows of the forest and the memory of the dead hobbit clung to them still, reminding them that the journey ahead would be far from simple.

The path wound steadily down from the hills, leaving the shadowed embrace of the Old Forest behind, though its presence lingered in the cool, damp air and the occasional rustle of leaves along the hedgerows. The morning sun spilled across the rolling fields, dappling the road with light and shadow, and the Brandywine shimmered faintly in the distance, a silver ribbon curling through the green.

Elric moved ahead, silent and assured, slipping through the scattered farmers and occasional wanderers as if he had walked this way a thousand times before. His figure was pale and lean, and though he passed among the humans with ease, there was a watchfulness in his stance — a constant attention to the edges of the road and the whispers of wind through the trees.

Marlo, Holman, and Briffo followed more hesitantly, their small hobbit feet crunching softly on the gravel. Each of them carried the weight of recent events in their minds — the dead hobbit, the coffer, the uneasy forest. The world beyond the Shire, even in these quiet fields, felt larger and less predictable.

“The forest... it never lets go completely,” Marlo murmured, glancing back over his shoulder.

Elric did not look back. “No. Even as it recedes, it leaves marks — in the air, in the ground, in those who pass through. Stay close. We are entering lands more traveled, but that does not mean they are without risk.”

The road widened as it neared the scattered farms and small homesteads that marked the approach to Bree. Men moved about their chores — tending cattle, repairing fences, or guiding small carts laden with vegetables and firewood. Horses snorted in the fields, and the distant hammering of a smith rang faintly on the morning air. The air was warmer here, carrying a hint of bread baking and woodsmoke, a welcome change from the chill of the forest.

Holman whispered to Marlo, “It feels... almost like home, yet not like the Shire at all. The land is too open, the people too busy.”

Briffo squinted at the horizon, where the first outlines of rooftops appeared, timber and plaster rising above the hedges and low stone walls. “Bree at last,” he said, voice tight with awe. “I’ve heard tales, but I never thought we would see it like this.”

Elric slowed as they reached a low bridge spanning a narrow stream, one of the first signs of the town proper. He glanced back at the hobbits. “From here, the town spreads across the low hills. Keep your heads down, and follow my lead. We move through streets crowded with humans, and though most are harmless, there are always eyes that notice what they should not.”

The hobbits stepped onto the bridge cautiously. Below, the water rippled over smooth stones, reflecting the sky in pale silver. On the far side, the streets of Bree wound in earnest — merchants’ stalls spilling onto the road, townsfolk moving with purpose, and the occasional horse-drawn cart rumbling over the cobbles. The town hummed with life, a sharp contrast to the quiet tension of the forest, yet a subtle unease clung to it, like a shadow that had followed them from the trees.

Marlo felt the weight of the coffer press against his back as they moved forward. Every glance, every sound of the bustling town made him conscious of how small they were in this human world. Holman and Briffo stayed close, murmuring quietly about the differences between the Shire and Bree, but even their light chatter could not dispel the sense that the forest's darkness had not yet released its hold.

Elric led them through the streets with a practiced ease, slipping between carts and pedestrians, keeping the hobbits just out of the throng's most watchful eyes. "Soon," he said, voice low, "we will find a place to speak with someone who understands these things. But first, we must reach the heart of the town."

And so they walked, the sound of distant hammers, voices, and the occasional clatter of a falling barrel mingling with the soft padding of hobbit feet, drawing them deeper into Bree — a town alive with human bustle, yet shadowed, still, by the forest they had left behind.

The road curved gently downward, and the shapes of rooftops began to punctuate the green of the hills. Chimneys rose, smoke curling in thin, pale streams into the morning air, and the sound of human voices drifted over the fields, a constant murmur of conversation, commerce, and daily toil. The scent of fresh-baked bread and woodsmoke carried faintly, mingling with the cool, lingering mist from the river valleys.

"Stay close," Elric murmured, slipping ahead of the hobbits with a quiet grace. His steps were sure, but cautious, as he navigated the throng of men moving along the road and spilling into the first buildings of the town. To a casual observer, he seemed merely a traveler, but there was a precision to his movements — the way he read the crowd, ducked between carts, and adjusted his pace — that marked him as someone not only of the world, but attuned to it in ways the hobbits could scarcely imagine.

Marlo and the others followed, their small figures ducking under cart wheels and weaving around merchants setting up tables and laying out wares. The shouts of traders, the clatter of iron and wood, and the occasional bark of a dog filled the air, all mingling into a lively chorus that seemed both inviting and overwhelming.

Holman whispered, "So many men... I had forgotten what Bree truly looks like."

Briffo nodded, glancing around with wide eyes. "And their voices! It is a different world from the Shire."

Elric moved between them and the human traffic, gently urging them to stay close. "Keep your wits about you," he said, voice low. "We do not want attention, yet we cannot move blindly. The town is mostly safe, but watch for shadows that linger at the edges."

As they entered the narrow street that led toward the center of Bree, the houses grew closer together, timber-framed with plaster walls, low thatch roofs, and signs swinging above the doors. Merchants called for attention: a grocer displaying casks of pickled vegetables, a blacksmith hammering thin sheets of iron into useful shapes, a baker lifting a tray of warm rolls from the oven. The hum of human life was constant, the rhythm of a town that had long existed at the crossroads of roads and peoples.

Marlo felt a mixture of awe and caution. The Shire was distant now, a quiet memory behind him, replaced by the buzz of a town that never truly paused. Yet even here, under the bright morning sun,

the forest lay not far behind, its shadows brushing against the edges of streets and gardens like a whispered warning.

Elric paused near a low bridge spanning a shallow stream, casting a glance back at the hobbits. “There,” he said quietly. “We are within the heart of Bree. Keep your heads down and your steps measured. The market is lively, the town watch alert, but there are those who notice things — and not all of them are welcoming.”

Marlo swallowed, feeling the weight of the coffer in his pack and the memory of the forest pressing against his mind. Strange times indeed, he thought, as the human town opened fully before them, bustling and vivid, and Elric led them deeper into the streets, weaving like a shadow through the crowd, the hobbits following in careful step.

The road narrowed as they followed Elric deeper into the heart of Bree, the hum of the town growing louder with every step. Soon, the market square opened before them, cobbled and irregular, as if laid down over centuries of use. Stalls of every shape and size lined the square, their bright cloths flapping in the morning breeze, and the air was rich with the mingling scents of baked bread, cured meats, and the faint tang of smoke from a dozen hearths.

A baker’s boy darted past, carrying a tray of steaming rolls, and a cartload of barrels groaned under the careful guidance of a stout man in a soot-streaked apron. Here and there, the familiar faces of townsfolk paused to nod or glance as they passed, murmuring softly to one another, “Back in the square again... same as ever.”

One of the stalls displayed brightly painted wooden toys, and a small girl clutched a painted horse, her mother’s hand resting lightly on her shoulder. A man arranging casks of cider looked up, catching sight of Elric and the hobbits. “Ah! Into the square at last,” he said, voice carrying just enough to be heard by a few nearby. “Market proper, as it should be. Good morning to you, strangers.”

Elric’s eyes flicked briefly to the man, nodding with the faintest of smiles. “Good morning,” he replied, soft but deliberate, his voice carrying that subtle lilting quality that marked him as something more than ordinary. He guided the hobbits along the edge of the square, keeping them close to the stalls, where the crowd was thickest.

Marlo’s eyes widened at the bustle, yet he noted the care with which Elric moved. “So many people... and yet we pass unnoticed,” he whispered to Holman.

Holman glanced around, craning his neck. “Unnoticed, yes... but only for a moment. Did you hear that man just say it’s proper market day? Even here, the old routines hold.”

The bustle of the market square gradually faded behind them as Elric led the hobbits down a narrow side street, cobbles worn smooth by centuries of passing feet. Voices and laughter softened into murmurs, the scent of bread and cider giving way to a cooler, earthier tang from small gardens tucked between buildings.

They passed the Prancing Pony, its sign swinging lightly in the breeze, painted with a horse in mid-leap. The tavern hummed with human chatter, the clatter of mugs, and the occasional burst of song. Elric cast a careful glance at the door and nodded toward the side alley beside it. “Not all knowledge is found in the square,” he said quietly. “Some answers lie in quieter places, where fewer eyes pry.”

Marlo, Holman, and Briffo followed closely, their steps muted on the narrow stones. At the alley's end, they came to a small doorway, almost hidden between two larger houses. It was low and narrow, framed in carved wood with gentle curves that reminded Marlo of hobbit architecture, yet tall enough and slender enough to suggest the touch of elvish design. The windows were arched with latticework of subtle, flowing patterns, half-elf, half-hobbit, as if the builder had sought to reconcile two ways of seeing the world.

Elric pushed the door open with a soft click, the hinges giving barely a sound. Inside, a faint warmth and the rich scent of oiled wood greeted them, along with shelves lined with small curiosities — carved figures, old maps, and stacks of parchment. The room seemed intimate yet taller than it appeared from the street, the ceiling curving gracefully overhead, suggesting a hand attuned to elegance as well as function.

"Here," Elric murmured, motioning the hobbits to follow, "we may speak more freely. And here, the coffer may be studied without prying eyes."

Marlo stepped cautiously inside, feeling the snug space hug him like a protective shell, yet sensing at once the unusual care in its design. "It is... different," he whispered, glancing at the elegant curves and warm glow of lantern light reflected off the polished wood. "Half-hobbit, half-elf... it almost feels alive."

Elric's eyes lingered on the shadows cast along the walls, his fingers brushing lightly over the bow at his back. "Architecture has memory," he said quietly, "as do those who make it. Here, in this place, both of our kinds — or, rather, all of the kinds we represent — may speak openly. But beware: the world outside is not yet settled, and the coffer's presence stirs more than curiosity."

The hobbits looked around in awe, their minds momentarily suspended from worry, fear, or wonder, letting the quietude of the place settle over them like a soft cloak. The room was small yet full of stories, and for the first time since leaving the Old Forest, they felt a tentative calm — though even here, the faint echoes of the wild, the strange, and the chaotic lingered, reminding them that peace was always provisional.

The little door shut behind them with a soft wooden thud, muffling the distant chatter of Bree's market square. The air inside was cooler, dimly lit by two oil lamps set into carved alcoves. The hallway was low-ceilinged but curved gracefully, the walls worked smooth like river stone, and the beams bore strange patterns — flowing Elvish lines interwoven with the sturdy, rounded flourishes of Hobbit-masonry. It was an odd mingling of crafts, neither wholly one nor the other, as though the builders themselves could not decide what they were meant to be.

Marlo slowed, his eyes flicking over the strange engravings. He touched one, tracing the looping script he didn't understand.

"What is this place?" he asked at last, his voice low, wary in the hush.

Elric didn't look up from the small, iron-bound coffer he had taken from the dead hobbit. He crouched on one knee beneath the soft lamplight, running his hands carefully across its seams, muttering under his breath in some clipped, ancient tongue. Without glancing at Marlo, he lifted his chin and gestured vaguely down a narrow side-passage.

"Go on," Elric said, distracted. "There is more to see, if you must satisfy your curiosity."

Marlo hesitated, casting a glance at the others. None of them spoke; the silence pressed in close here, as though the walls themselves were holding their breath. Finally, he stepped softly down the passage, the wooden floor creaking faintly beneath his boots.

At first, the side corridor was unremarkable, lined with rounded archways and shallow alcoves, but then he turned the corner — and stopped dead in his tracks.

There, in a small low-ceilinged chamber, sat a family. A hobbit mother and father, two children tucked close between them, and an elderly grandmother hunched beneath a thin shawl. Their faces were pale and taut with fear. The father clutched a long, curved knife that looked far too heavy for him, while the mother's arms were wrapped tight around the youngest child. A single candle burned low between them, its wick trembling as though it feared to be snuffed out.

The narrow passageway opened suddenly into a low, lamplit chamber, and Marlo drew up short upon its threshold. The room was warmer than the damp alleys of Bree outside, scented faintly of woodsmoke and herbs hung drying from the rafters. At first, the sight bewildered him: a family gathered there, six small faces turned upward in wide-eyed astonishment.

One of the children—a boy no taller than Marlo's shoulder, yet sharp-faced like his father—breathed out, "A hobbit!" The word carried not derision, but a lilting cadence, as though from lips long accustomed to speaking Elvish words beside their Westron.

From where he crouched by a small hearth, an older child said softly, "Truly, father has brought a halfling."

Marlo, blinking beneath so many curious gazes, managed an awkward bow.

Before he could stammer out a greeting, Elric's voice sounded behind him, steady and grave, though tinged with a warmth that Marlo had seldom heard:

"These are my kin, Marlo," he said, stepping into the chamber. He knelt to greet the children in turn, placing a hand gently upon each head as he named them, his voice ringing in that slightly elevated lilt his people carried, halfway between the weight of Men and the grace of Elves.

"This is Aelwyn," he began, nodding to the eldest, a tall girl with pale hair bound in a ribbon of silver thread. "And beside her, her brother Corin, ever the bold." The boy grinned at Marlo with unabashed curiosity.

"Elira," he said next, the second daughter, "keeper of songs and quiet wisdom." She gave Marlo a shy but luminous smile.

"Thalen," he continued, resting a hand upon the dark curls of the youngest son, "swift of foot and fleet of thought."

"And these two," he said at last, glancing fondly toward the smallest pair huddled together by the hearth, "are Myriel and Faenor. They share one heart and one mischief."

The twins beamed, emboldened by the kindness in Elric's tone.

Marlo's gaze, wandering beyond the children, settled upon the woman who had risen silently from a carved oaken chair at the far side of the room. She was striking—not tall, but poised, and there was a grace in her movement that reminded Marlo of the deep woods at twilight. Her hair, dark as

riverstone, caught glints of the lamplight, and her grey eyes—keen, watchful, and bright—seemed to hold some quiet knowing of their own.

Elric's voice softened as he turned slightly, extending a hand toward her.

"And this," he said, as though the words bore weight, "is Lyriana."

She inclined her head—not as the hobbits might, with rustic familiarity, but with a quiet courtesy that carried the echo of elder days.

"It is rare," she said, her voice soft yet deliberate, "to see one of the Periannath wander so far north and west, and rarer still to welcome one into our house." She paused, her gaze resting warmly upon Marlo, and then added, "Be at ease beneath our roof, sons of the Shire."

Marlo swallowed, unsure whether to bow or sit or simply melt into the shadows, and ended up doing a little of all three. The children laughed softly, and Corin, boldest of them, stepped forward to peer at Marlo's feet as though confirming some whispered rumour about hobbits and their lack of shoes.

Elric, meanwhile, had carried the small iron coffer to a low, candle-lit table set near the wall. With slow, measured care, he began brushing away the dirt that clung to its edges, running his thumb over the strange markings etched into the lid. His silence weighed upon the room, for it was clear his thoughts had turned elsewhere—back to the dead hobbit in the undergrowth, and to the dark tidings stitched into that box's presence so far west.

Six children of varying age, their hair carrying a soft, silvery sheen beneath which hints of autumnal curls betrayed their hobbit blood. Their ears were slightly pointed, their faces narrower than those of the Shirefolk but holding the warmth of halflings' cheer.

From the another side, soft footsteps approached, and a woman emerged from another passage — tall for a hobbit, but shorter than any elf Marlo had ever imagined. Her ears were faintly pointed, her dark hair braided and pinned with a small silver clasp, and her eyes carried the soft brightness of starlight reflected in deep water.

"Elric," she said gently, and her voice had a clarity to it, like the sound of wind threading leaves. "I felt you near, but I did not think..." Her gaze moved across Marlo and the other hobbits with curious surprise, yet without suspicion. "Guests. Unexpected ones."

Elric's expression softened. "Serenya," he said, his voice lowering as though her presence made him quieter, steadier. "These are Marlo, Samlin, and Tobold, hobbits from the Shire."

She rose first, her voice lilting, faintly musical:

"A hobbit," she said with quiet wonder, her hand resting lightly against the back of one of her daughters. "We seldom meet one face to face."

A ripple of delight passed through the children. One of the younger boys, no more than eight or nine, whispered in a hushed voice,

"Real hobbits..."

Elric, who had moved softly into the room behind them, smiled faintly at their awe, the expression rare and quiet on his weathered face. He inclined his head toward the woman, speaking gently:

The children bowed slightly, as though by long habit, their manners graceful yet unstudied.

Marlo, still trying to recover his breath, finally found his voice:

“I... I’ve heard tell of half-elves,” he said cautiously, “but I can’t recall a single good telling of half-elven... half-hobbits. Only faint hearings. Fireside whispers.”

Linwen smiled faintly at that, a sadness woven into its edges. Elric stepped forward then, settling the small coffer he had carried onto the edge of the table. As his fingers brushed the lid, his gaze drifted briefly to Marlo.

“There are few who know of us, and fewer still who speak of it plainly,” Elric said. “We have kept ourselves well hidden. The lines we carry here trace back before the ending of the Third Age, when the last echoes of the Great War still haunted these woods.”

Samlin frowned, tilting his head, his small curls bobbing slightly as he asked:

“The Third Age? That doesn’t fit with Shire reckoning. What year would that be?”

At this, one of the elder children—Lira, perhaps twelve and already showing her mother’s composure—answered softly before Elric could:

“Your reckoning begins late, Little Master. The Third Age ended more than two hundred years ago, by your calendars.”

Tobold gave a low whistle, looking from Marlo to Samlin and back again.

The firelight crackled gently. Outside, somewhere beyond the small round window, Bree’s market hummed faintly—its noise distant now, as though they had stepped clean out of one world and into another.

Elric’s hand lingered on the coffer, tracing the carved sigils along its lid. “These are strange days indeed,” he said at last, voice low, almost to himself.

Lyriana moved to his side, placing a hand lightly upon his arm. “This is no trinket, is it?” she murmured.

Elric did not answer at once. His gaze lingered on the carvings, and when he finally spoke, it was scarcely above a whisper:

“No... not a trinket. And its journey here may bring shadows trailing after it.”

Finally, Elric exhaled, low and steady, as though admitting something to himself.

“This... this is older than any of us guessed,” he said quietly, his voice carrying just enough to fill the hush of the chamber. “Older than Bree. Older than the Mark. Older than the very paths the Rangers walk.”

The children hushed at once, watching him with wide, unblinking eyes. Elric’s wife, Serenya, rested a hand lightly against his arm, her expression caught between worry and knowing.

Marlo swallowed. “Older than the Third Age?” he ventured.

Elric’s jaw tightened, and he gave a slow nod. “Older than the end of it, aye... older than the wars men sing about, older than the towers that fell.”

One of the other hobbits — Tolly, still pale from the forest — frowned, scratching behind his ear. “What’s *that* in Shire years?”

Elric managed the ghost of a smile, though it faded as quickly as it came. “Before your count began. Before Hobbits came to the Brandywine. Before we even knew what dark lay under the mountains.”

He turned back to the coffer, fingertips brushing the delicate sigils burned into its grain. The patterns shimmered faintly in the candlelight, almost alive.

“I thought these were lost,” he whispered. “The last echoes of the Ainur’s making... buried, scattered, forgotten.”

Marlo’s stomach twisted at the name — *Ainur* — a word older than old tales, a whisper of beings who shaped the world before even the stars were counted.

Outside, the muted clamour of Bree’s market carried faintly through the timbered walls — merchants haggling, hooves clattering on stone — but within this quiet chamber beneath the half-elven arch, it felt impossibly far away.

Elric turned back to them, the weight of unspoken knowledge shadowing his eyes.

“We are walking paths that were sealed for an age,” he said. “Whatever killed that hobbit, whatever drove the wargs this far west — it is part of something vast. Something stirring. And if the Ainur’s relics are waking...”

He trailed off, the candle guttering as though even the flame feared his words.

“...then all of Arda will feel it.”

The room was silent but for the soft, steady breathing of the children. Somewhere beyond the far door, a bell tolled in Bree, marking the turning of the hour — ordinary, indifferent, unaware of what shadows lengthened beyond its walls.

Elric set the coffer down, gently, as though afraid it might splinter under its own burden.

“Rest now,” he said at last, his voice quiet but resolved. “For come morning, none of us walk the same road we thought we did.”

Chapter Four:

Marlo came in last, pulling his travelling cloak about his shoulders as though to guard himself against the weight of what he had stepped into. His round face was lit strangely by the soft amber glow from the sconces along the wall. Behind him padded the other two hobbits, Thomlin and Celandine, their bright eyes wide and restless, as if trying to drink in every detail at once.

Elric knelt before the small coffer on the stone pedestal, its lid half-open, the strange script shimmering faintly where the lamplight struck it. Beside him lay a weathered book, its pages covered in delicate tengwar, and the faint impression of older, stranger runes beneath them. He hummed softly at first, a single note drawn into being, then allowed it to ripple outward into fragments of melody — the high, searching tones of a language that felt older than stone, older than even the long memory of Bree.

Marlo hesitated by the doorway, watching him.

“What is it?” he asked at last, voice low but edged with awe. “And why are you... singing to it?”

Elric did not turn at once, his eyes fixed on the fine silver lettering along the coffer's edge. His hand brushed the page of his book as though drawing guidance from its script, the notes of his song rising, falling — testing the weight of each sound against the hidden pattern of the inscription.

"I am attempting," Elric said softly, "to weave back what once was. The coffer bears a tongue almost lost — the echoes of the Ainur, perhaps, though twisted by long ages of forgetting. It was not meant to be read merely with the eye, Marlo. It requires... harmony."

Celandine frowned slightly, stepping nearer. "Ainur?" she whispered, glancing sidelong at Thomlin. "We've only the faintest hearsay of such things in the Shire. That's old talk — *far* older than our folk, isn't it?"

Elric's voice deepened with a shadowed kind of reverence. "Older, yes... and more than you imagine. This place, this hidden network — it was laid long before Men came to Bree, before Hobbits crossed the Brandywine. There are pathways here, Marlo, marked and warded in ways few now remember. Serenya's kin were among those who kept the knowledge when the Third Age waned and the Fourth began. They hid themselves, and wisely so."

Thomlin scratched at his curls, his brow furrowed. "Third Age?" he asked, puzzled. "By Shire Reckoning, what's that come to?"

Elric's gaze softened, though he did not look away from the coffer. "By your calendars, it ended well before your great-grandfathers were born," he murmured. "Before the Red Book was sealed. But here..." He touched the shining edge of the inscription. "...here, fragments endure. Secrets that should not have slept."

Serenya stepped forward then, laying a hand lightly on his shoulder. Her voice was clear, lilting, carrying an almost musical cadence of its own. "Elric believes this coffer may hold a memory — not words alone, but song. The ancient harmonies shaped the world once, before it was broken and remade. If he is right..." Her eyes glanced toward Marlo and the other hobbits, "...then it may remember what we have long forgotten."

The melody Elric sang began to shift then, deepening, as if his voice had found a thread hidden beneath the surface — a line of quiet power humming in reply. The light along the coffer's edge flared, briefly alive, and the small chamber seemed to breathe.

Marlo swallowed, drawing the cloak tighter about himself. "And if you wake what sleeps in there," he said softly, "what then?"

Elric closed his eyes, fingers resting against the script. "Then we will finally know why this place was hidden," he murmured. "And why Bree was built where it was."

The faint hum lingered, carrying with it something older than language — a whisper of a song that might have been the first sound of the world.

Bree lay muted in the early light, the air still damp from a fine mist that clung to the cobblestones. The market had begun to stir behind them, the scents of pipeweed, bread, and leather lingering faintly as Elric led them out of the bustle, weaving through the press of humans with the fluid ease of someone accustomed to walking unnoticed among them. Marlo kept close, his travelling cloak pulled tight, while Tobold and Samlin lagged a few steps behind, whispering to one another about the half-hidden glances they'd caught from the Bree-folk.

They slipped down a narrow lane past the Prancing Pony, its familiar oak doors thrown open to the early risers and its deep, warm laughter spilling faintly into the street. But Elric did not pause. Instead, he stopped before a tiny door set discreetly between two weathered beams, its frame carved in soft, flowing arcs — neither wholly elvish nor wholly hobbit-built, but somewhere between, as though two arts had been fused into a single quiet secret. Without knocking, he pressed his hand flat to the wood. A faint hum, almost imperceptible, passed through the grain. Then the door yielded, and they stepped inside.

The first chamber was low but graceful, faintly lit by small glass lamps set into niches. Scrolls and coffered chests lined the walls, their wood stained deep and ancient. Elric's gaze fell immediately upon one such coffer on the far table, its polished surface inlaid with intricate, curling script. His brow furrowed, and without a word, he moved toward it, fingertips brushing delicately across the markings as though afraid the touch might awaken something sleeping beneath.

Marlo, still wrapped in his cloak, paused, watching him closely. The half-light caught on his curls and the faint sheen of travel-dust. Finally, he stepped forward, lowering his voice:

"Elric... what is it?"

Elric did not answer at first. Instead, he drew a slender, leather-bound book from the shelf beside the coffer and set it open upon the table. The pages were inked with dense elvish script, diagrams, and fragments of song. He hummed softly under his breath — a low, wavering tone that shifted as though seeking its own shape, like water searching for the banks of a river. Marlo realised, with a sudden shiver, that Elric was singing. Not words, not yet — but the bones of a melody, something older than speech itself.

Samlin and Tobold exchanged glances, unease mingling with curiosity. Samlin leaned close to Marlo, whispering:

"I've only ever heard of half-elves, half-hobbits... faint echoes of stories from over Westfarthing. Folk said they were gone long before my grandsire's time."

Tobold nodded, his voice quiet but steady: *"Never thought I'd see one standing before me."*

Elric looked up from the coffer then, his grey eyes settling on them with a faint, knowing smile. His voice, when he spoke, had the measured cadence of someone long-practised in weighing words:

"You would not have seen us. We have kept ourselves hidden, bound to shadows and quiet paths. There are not many left of our kind — fewer still who bear the old blood true. But our network..." He traced a line along the edge of the coffer, fingertips lingering on an etching that seemed to shimmer faintly under the lamplight. *"...our memory stretches back before the end of the Third Age."*

Tobold blinked and frowned, confused: *"Third Age? What's that in Shire Reckoning, then?"*

Before Elric could answer, a soft rustling came from the adjoining room. Serenya stepped into the doorway — her presence immediate, as though the air bent faintly toward her. She was striking, though not in the way of great beauty carved and deliberate. Her grace was quieter, woven into the tilt of her head, the stillness of her hands, the pale sweep of her hair that caught the faintest gleam of silver even in this dim light.

Serenya's gaze passed over them all in turn, pausing on Marlo, Tobold, and Samlin. A warmth touched her features — not surprise, exactly, but something like recognition after a long absence.

"Hobbits," she said softly, and there was music in her voice, light but resonant. *"It has been long indeed since we welcomed any of your kind beneath this roof. You are most welcome here."*

Elric inclined his head toward her, his voice quieter now, as though her presence tempered him:

"Serenya, these are Marlo, Tobold, and Samlin — travellers of the Shire."

She nodded in greeting, then moved toward the table, laying one hand lightly upon Elric's shoulder, her gaze lowering to the coffer. The hum of his song deepened, and for a moment, the soft air of the room seemed to tighten around them, as though waiting for something to awaken beneath the melody.

Elric's voice sank, barely above a breath:

"If I can find the thread of the Ainulindalë — if I can match the echo — the coffer may reveal its purpose. This script... it is old, older than Bree, older than Arnor's stones. I think it remembers the first Music."

Elric sat hunched at the low table, the coffer before him — no ordinary chest but an ancient thing of dark, silver-veined oak, its surface etched with strange runes and faint tracery. A worn book lay open beside him, filled with looping Tengwar, half-faded annotations in Westron, and fragments of song. Across from him stood Serenya, her quiet grace tempered by an unspoken tension, her slender hands resting lightly on the edge of the table.

Marlo, Tobold, and Samlin lingered near the doorway, watching silently, cloaks still dusted from their journey. Marlo's hood was drawn close, and his hand clutched the folds of his travelling cloak as though he weren't sure whether to step forward or keep his distance.

Elric traced the edge of the coffer with his fingers, lips moving faintly as he murmured words half-spoken, half-sung, the melody uneven as though searching for something just beyond reach — a broken echo of the old Music, the first Music, the Ainulindalë itself.

Serenya's gaze, deep and steady, lingered on him. "You should rest," she said softly, though there was no command in her voice, only concern. "Your thoughts are wandering into places even the Eldar once feared to tread."

Elric shook his head without looking up, his voice low and frayed at the edges. "This is older than I imagined, Serenya. Older than Bree, older than the Shire. Look here—" He tapped the carved lid with one long finger, the rune flaring faintly under the lamplight. "These shapes — they don't match the Third Age scripts. They reach further back, beyond the reckoning of most loremasters."

Serenya moved closer, the soft fall of her skirts brushing the polished floor. "And yet you try to wake it," she murmured.

"I try," Elric admitted, glancing at the open book. "I thought... if I could recall the cadences of the Ainur, even in fragments, perhaps it would answer." He paused, letting the silence stretch, his hand resting lightly on the coffer's surface as though afraid it might stir beneath his touch.

Marlo shifted at the doorway, his voice breaking softly into the quiet. "What... what is it, Elric? What could possibly be hidden in something so small?"

Elric glanced up, his expression unreadable, as though measuring the weight of his next words. Finally, he exhaled and sat back slightly, folding his arms.

“I cannot yet say,” he said slowly, “but if the song etched here speaks true, this coffer may hold more worth than any vault beneath Erebor or crown in Gondor.” He met Serenya’s gaze for a moment, and there was both awe and unease in his voice. “More than I could ever know.”

Tobold whistled under his breath. Samlin leaned against the frame, arms crossed, eyes wide with mingled curiosity and caution.

“And if it’s worth that much,” Serenya said softly, “someone will come seeking it.”

Elric’s hand froze on the table. He looked at her, and for the first time that night, there was a shadow in his face — not fear exactly, but a dawning awareness of consequence.

“Yes,” he said at last, barely louder than a whisper. “And who... who would pay such a price?”

The small chamber, lit by two hanging lamps of soft golden glass, had fallen utterly still except for Elric’s measured breathing. The coffer — carved in pale ashwood, banded with sigils half-buried in time — rested open before him, its surface like a frozen ripple of meaning he had not yet managed to untangle.

Serenya sat cross-legged on the low bench opposite, her long fingers folded neatly into her lap, her expression poised between worry and wonder. Beyond the half-open doorway, Tobold and Samlin murmured softly together while Marlo, still wrapped in his travelling cloak, leaned against the lintel, watching with bright curiosity.

Elric turned a single page in the worn vellum tome beside him, tracing a line of Quenya script with the tip of one long nail. His voice dropped low, threaded with quiet intensity.

“If the text is true,” he said, not looking up, “this isn’t merely a coffer. It’s... a vessel. A fragment of something older than the crowns of Men or the high cities of the Eldar. Before Númenor fell. Before the shaping of the Shire.”

Serenya tilted her head, her voice low but rich, carrying that slightly elevated cadence the half-elven kin shared — smooth and musical, though never ostentatious.

“You speak as though it bears the memory of Arda’s first music,” she said softly. “But what would such a thing be doing here, beneath Bree of all places?”

Elric finally glanced up at her, his pale eyes glinting like caught starlight.

“I cannot answer that,” he admitted. “Only that this... script, these harmonics — they are closer to the language of the Ainur than anything I have studied.”

At that, Marlo took a tentative step closer, his cloak swaying about his small frame.

“Ainur?” he asked, blinking up at them. “You mean the... the first singers? That’s what the old tales say, back in the Shire. Songs that built the world.”

Elric gave a faint smile, though his tone was solemn.

“Aye, Marlo. Songs that shaped mountains, seas, and stars — sung before the first dawn. But this...” He gestured to the coffer, “...this may hold an echo of that melody. A thread woven into silence, left for some purpose I cannot yet see.”

Serenya leaned forward now, her dark hair slipping over one shoulder, her gaze intent.

“And if you are right?” she asked. “If this is what you believe — if it carries a fragment of their Song — then it may be worth more than you could ever reckon.”

Elric exhaled slowly, staring down at the strange runes as though they might reveal their secrets through sheer patience.

“Perhaps,” he murmured. “But who might *pay* for such a thing, Serenya? Who would dare *claim* the echo of the Ainur’s music and believe they could hold it? The Elves would guard it. The Dúnedain might covet it. And Men...” He hesitated, his jaw tightening. “Men would likely try to break it, thinking there is power trapped within.”

For a moment, silence gathered in the small chamber, thick and brittle. The only sound was the faint crackle of the lamp’s oil.

Then Elric straightened, his jaw set, and closed his eyes.

“One more attempt,” he said quietly. “Riskier... but if the harmonics match, it may wake something.”

Marlo frowned. “Wake... what exactly?”

Elric didn’t answer. He set his fingertips lightly along the carved rim of the coffer and began to hum — softly at first, the pitch carefully measured, deliberate. It wasn’t an ordinary tune, nor a song of the Elves, nor even an echo of mortal music. It was closer to resonance than melody, an attempt to replicate the patterns described in his book — the layered, fractal harmonies of the Ainulindalë.

The air grew heavier, as though the room itself were leaning in to listen.

Serenya’s hand tightened around the bench. Tobold and Samlin had crept closer, wide-eyed and silent.

The hum deepened, Elric’s voice bending into strange intervals — and then, just for the briefest heartbeat, something beneath the sound stirred.

A tremor, almost inaudible, rippled through the air. The lamps flickered. The coffer gave a single, soft *chime* — as though struck from within by an unseen hand.

Elric gasped and broke off, his breath ragged, his knuckles pale where they gripped the lid.

“Did you hear that?” Marlo whispered, eyes wide.

Serenya nodded slowly, her voice hushed, reverent.

“Something *listened*.”

Elric wiped the sweat from his brow, his gaze fixed on the coffer like a man standing at the threshold of a storm.

“And something,” he said softly, “answered.”

Serenya sat cross-legged on the woven mat opposite him, her head bowed, the faint silver sheen of her hair catching the firelight. The six children were asleep in the inner alcove, their soft breathing forming a delicate rhythm beneath the faint crackle of the fire. Her gaze, however, was fixed on the

coffer lying between them—the carved, ancient thing that Elric now treated with something between awe and obsession. Its surface seemed to shimmer oddly when the fire caught it just so, the runes across its face neither wholly Elvish nor Dwarvish, yet imbued with a strange, solemn gravity.

“You’ve been staring at it for hours,” Serenya murmured softly, her voice a gentle melody. “If you keep at it so, Elric, you will convince yourself it whispers.”

Elric’s long fingers hovered above the carved lid, but he did not touch it. He exhaled slowly through his nose, his brows furrowed in deep concentration. “Perhaps it does,” he said at last. “This craft... this script... it is not merely old, Serenya. I think it may be *older than Bree itself*. Older than the settling of Hobbits here. Perhaps older than the founding of Arnor.”

Her gaze sharpened at that, the faintest flicker of unease passing across her face. “Older than Arnor?” she repeated. “Then it comes from a time before men ruled these lands.”

Elric nodded. “I can’t yet read the inscription in full, but what fragments I have untangled... they speak of beginnings, of songs, of light shaping form. If this is what I suspect it is—if this coffer carries relics or writings from before the Second Age—then its worth cannot be measured in gold.”

Serenya leaned back slightly, her fingers resting lightly on her knee, her tone cool and thoughtful. “And yet worth *must* be measured,” she countered gently. “There are those who would pay dearly for knowledge older than kingdoms, and there are those who would kill for it.” Her silver-grey eyes met his. “You have not considered that danger enough, husband.”

He hesitated, as if weighing her words, before sighing. “Perhaps not. But tell me, Serenya, who among the Free Peoples could buy such a thing? Who has the coin—or the will—to pay for what even the Wise might not fully comprehend?”

“The Wise,” Serenya echoed softly, as though tasting the thought. She was silent for a moment, her gaze flickering toward the tiny windows, as though searching beyond Bree’s familiar streets and toward the far-off hills and hidden roads. “Rivendell still whispers with song, though it sleeps. And there are scholars in Minas Tirith, deep in the Houses of Lore, who chase knowledge more fiercely than any dragon guards gold. The Dwarves of the Blue Mountains... they hoard secrets as fiercely as coin.”

“And the price?” Elric murmured.

She gave him a pointed look. “Secrets for secrets, perhaps. Or favour heavier than gold. You might part with this coffer and find yourself bound to debts you cannot yet see.”

He fell quiet at that, eyes lowering back to the carved box. His thumb traced absently over the open book beside him, following the faded Tengwar script as though it might yield its mysteries through persistence alone.

At length, Serenya’s voice softened. “Elric,” she said, almost a whisper, “perhaps we should not decide this alone. There are those wiser than we, whose counsel might keep us from peril. Perhaps... we should seek them.”

He looked up sharply, studying her face in silence, as though balancing his hunger for knowledge against the weight of her caution. At last, he nodded slowly. “Outside advice,” he echoed, the words tasting unfamiliar on his tongue. “If the age is what I think it is... yes. Someone must know more.”

And yet, even as he said it, his gaze returned to the coffer with a quiet possessiveness he did not name.

Before either could speak again, a faint sound stirred in the deeper passages—light footsteps padding softly over stone. Marlo emerged into the firelight, cloak drawn tightly around him against the damp of the lower halls, his round face shadowed beneath his hood. He looked from Elric to Serenya, then down at the coffer, his curiosity plain.

“What is it?” Marlo asked quietly, pulling his cloak tighter as though the air here had grown colder. “why does it feel as though it’s waiting?”

Elric said nothing for a moment, only reached to turn a page in his book, his lips moving faintly as if shaping silent notes. Then, glancing at the hobbit, he murmured, “I am trying... to hear its song.”

His fingers brushed the coffer’s surface and, ever so softly, he began to hum—a fragment of the ancient melody he had been studying, the *Ainur*’s *music* itself, fragile and imperfect upon mortal lips.

Somewhere deep within the coffer, something faint... *stirred*.

The fire burned low, shadows stretching long across the carved beams of Elric’s study. The strange coffin lay between them on the wide oak table, its pale surface glowing faintly in the lamplight. Elric leaned forward, running his fingers gently along the etched patterns — fragments of ancient script tangled with what seemed like musical notation. Serenya sat close by, her eyes reflecting the lamplight, while Marlo stood just behind them, arms folded beneath his travelling cloak.

Elric exhaled sharply, his tone quiet but edged with urgency. "This... whatever it is... I am no longer certain we should keep it hidden. Its value may be beyond reckoning — greater than I can yet fathom. But if we cannot even date it, we cannot bargain for it. Someone — somewhere — must know what this is."

Serenya rested a hand lightly on the table, brushing away a curl of dark hair from her face. "You believe it is that old? Older even than the end of the Third Age?"

Elric nodded gravely. "Older, perhaps. Or else tied to things that were never meant for mortal keeping." He paused, lowering his voice. "But aye... if we could prove its age, there are collectors in Minas Tirith and Dol Amroth who would fight kingdoms to possess such a relic. Or even kings themselves."

Serenya considered this for a long moment, then said softly: "And yet you do not know its worth. Nor who might seek it... or why."

Marlo, restless, stepped forward, the hem of his cloak brushing the polished stone floor.

"Then find someone who does!" the hobbit said sharply. "There must be sages who live for things like this. Someone who studies the First Music, or Elvish craft, or... or whatever this blasted box is."

Elric’s gaze stayed fixed on the coffin, his expression unreadable. "I am not qualified to pass judgement," he admitted. "We will need an expert."

Marlo frowned thoughtfully, rubbing his chin. "What of the wizards? There was one, wasn’t there, long ago — the Grey One, they called him. Gandalf the Wise. Folk said he knew more than any king’s library ever held."

Elric's face softened, though there was regret in his eyes. "Gandalf has sailed into the West, beyond mortal reach. He will not return."

A silence followed, broken only by the crackle of the fire. Finally, Elric continued: "There is another, though — Radagast the Brown. He keeps mostly to himself, dwelling near the edges of Mirkwood, though on occasion he hides out near the Old Forest. Some whisper he speaks more to birds than to men, and most regard him as... eccentric."

Marlo snorted. "Eccentric, is it? Sounds no worse than most hobbits after a few pints."

Serenya turned her head, her voice quiet but steady. "I have heard tales from the wandering Elves — there are two others yet, blue-robed wizards, though their paths lead far east, into lands no hobbit or man dares name. If they live still, they are beyond our reach."

Marlo frowned deeper, his fingers twitching nervously. "So... no Gandalf, no Elves, no wandering blue sorcerers. That leaves us with a hermit who talks to birds."

Elric gave a thin smile. "Perhaps. But there may be one more... someone stranger still."

Marlo raised a brow. "And who might that be?"

Elric hesitated, almost reluctant to speak the name aloud. "There are old songs of a figure called Tom Bombadil — a creature as ancient as the hills, some say, and older than the rivers themselves. Not a wizard, nor Elf, nor Man, but something else entirely. If the coffin is bound to the First Music, as I suspect... he may know the tune better than any living soul."

Serenya tilted her head, thoughtful. "If he still walks beneath the trees..."

Marlo blew out a breath, shaking his head. "A box carved with songs older than time itself, and now we're off chasing ghost stories. Brilliant. Just brilliant."

Elric didn't reply. His hand rested upon the strange coffin, and his gaze burned with quiet resolve.

"If it speaks of the Music of the Ainur... then we must find someone who still remembers the melody."

Elric closed the book with a soft *thump* and rubbed his temples. "I cannot pass judgment on this," he said quietly, his voice hoarse from a night spent without rest. "Not alone. If what I suspect is true — if this was wrought before even the First Age — then it's worth more than I could ever dream"

Serenya stepped forward, brushing her hand lightly over the coffer's carved edge. "If its age can be proven," she said softly, "there are collectors, kings, perhaps even the hidden Elves still west of the Shire. But we'd need more than whispers and guesswork. We would need... outside counsel."

Marlo, still slouched, looked up sharply at that. "Outside counsel? There's none better than the wizards for such riddles." He leaned forward, voice low and urgent. "What of Gandalf? Was he not an expert in matters such as these?"

Elric gave a slow shake of his head. "Gandalf the Grey has sailed into the West, Marlo. He does not walk these lands anymore, nor will he return."

Marlo frowned but pressed on. "Then Radagast, perhaps. I've heard tell of him, though he keeps to himself, deep in the wild places."

“Radagast the Brown,” Elric said, considering the thought for a moment, “is said to dwell far to the south now. Some say he wanders Greenwood and the far reaches beyond. We could lose months searching for him.”

At this, Serenya spoke gently, as though reluctant to voice it: “There are still two more wizards,” she said. “I heard tales once from an Elf passing through Bree—blue-clad wanderers, who vanished into the East long ago. But none have seen them in an age, and I fear their knowledge lies far beyond our reach.”

Silence stretched for a few moments, broken only by the faint hiss of the candle.

Then Elric’s brow furrowed. “...There is *another*, though not one of the Istari.” He hesitated, lowering his voice even further, as though speaking of him might summon him. “Tom Bombadil. Some call him the eldest, though none truly know what he is. The Elves know him, though even they cannot name his nature. They say his power lies deep in song, deeper even than the Ainur’s melodies.”

Marlo sat bolt upright, cloak falling from his shoulders. “Then it’s decided,” he said with sudden, fierce determination, his weariness replaced by resolve. “We leave for the Old Forest at once.”

Serenya blinked, startled. “Marlo, you haven’t even slept. You cannot—”

“We *must*,” Elric cut her off. “Every moment we sit here, doing nothing, the chance to understand this passes further from us. Tobold and Samlin can remain here in Bree under your care, Serenya. Marlo and I will go—this very morning.”

Elric hesitated, glancing at his wife, but finally nodded, fastening the leather strap of his satchel. “If Tom knows anything of this—if *anyone* does—it will be him. We’ll take the south road, skirt the Barrow-downs, and enter the Old Forest by afternoon.”

Marlo was already on his feet, tightening his belt, his travelling cloak sweeping behind him as he moved for the door. “Then it’s settled,” he said, his voice steady. “By sunset, we’ll have our answer.”

Serenya remained silent, her gaze lingering on the coffer, the faint, unearthly glow still shimmering along its carved edges.

She whispered softly, as though to herself, “Or more questions than we ever wished to ask.”

Chapter 5: Into the Old Forest

Morning came pale and thin over Bree, and the first light touched the cobbled lanes like a cautious hand. The air was cool and damp with the memory of night, and a low mist clung to the hedgerows beyond the town walls. Elric and Marlo stood by the East-gate as the watchman, still yawning and rubbing his eyes, drew back the heavy bar and wished them luck in a voice that carried no great hope.

It was an uneasy parting. Serenya remained behind with Tobold and Samlin, and though she smiled bravely as she watched them go, there was a shadow in her eyes that neither Elric nor Marlo failed to see.

The road from Bree ran east and dipped low between rising banks before curling away southwards, where the lands grew wilder and the trees closer. Few now came that way by choice, and fewer still spoke lightly of what lay beyond the hedge and the barrow-dells.

Marlo pulled his cloak tight about his shoulders and glanced often at the silent woods ahead. "I have heard tales of the Old Forest since I was a lad," he muttered, "but none that made me eager to see it. Folk say it listens, Elric — listens and remembers."

Elric, walking with his head bent and his pack slung over one shoulder, did not answer at once. He was deep in thought, though his hand rested always on the small, weathered book that hung at his belt, as if it held a charm of safety. At length he said, quietly:

"Then let us hope it remembers kindly. For if there is wisdom in these lands still unspoiled by time, we shall need it — or this journey will be a short one."

And so, beneath a sky of soft grey, the two set their feet towards the ancient eaves where shadow and song lay tangled. Somewhere ahead, beyond bramble and hill, waited the Old Forest... and perhaps one who still walked its secret paths.

"It troubles me still," he said quietly. "What we saw yester-eve in the fringe of the Old Forest."

Elric slowed, his gaze distant on the horizon where the dark eaves lay in shadow. "Aye," he said at length. "I cannot set it from my mind either. A warg, this far west..." He shook his head, troubled. "It should not be. Not since the North was cleared in the old wars. Even in the fell days of Angmar, they rarely came beyond the Weather Hills."

Marlo scowled, tugging his cloak tighter. "Then why now? Has something roused them, Elric? Or driven them from their own haunts? I've heard talk in Bree — whispers of strange fires seen from the Barrow-downs, and dark shapes crossing the Greenway at night. Folk say it's only wild beasts, but..." He hesitated. "I do not think so."

Elric glanced back at him, his voice low. "It is no beast that leaves wounds like those we found on that poor hobbit by the hedge-row. That was no accident of tooth or claw."

Marlo shuddered, remembering. The image was not easily forgotten: the hobbit lying still beneath a hawthorn bush, his face pale and drawn, his small hand clutching a broken pipe-stem. The ground around him had been torn and muddied, and the leaves nearby were dark with dried blood.

"He can't have been gone long," Marlo said, swallowing hard. "And Bree-folk say no hobbits have come this far east from the Shire in years. What was he doing there, alone?"

"That is the darker question," Elric murmured. "Something drove him into the wilds — or lured him there. And if wargs are hunting here, there's purpose behind it. They do not roam so far without a hand guiding them."

For a while they walked in silence, the only sound the crunch of their boots on the winding path. A soft wind stirred through the heather and carried with it the damp scent of the distant trees.

At last, Marlo said, "Do you think this is... the same as before? Like the old days, when the Shadow rose in the East?"

Elric frowned but did not immediately answer. His eyes lingered on the edge of the Old Forest, where the sunlight failed and the trunks loomed close like sentries keeping a secret. When he finally spoke, his voice was heavy with thought.

“The world does not stay still, Marlo. The victories of old grow faint in the memory of men, and the lands shift beneath our feet. Old powers sleep — but not forever. If wargs are walking under these boughs, and hobbits are dying where none should wander... something stirs again.”

Marlo spat into the grass, muttering darkly. “I’ll be glad enough when we’ve found this Bombadil, if he even exists. Folk in Bree talk of him like he’s half a dream.”

Elric’s mouth curved faintly, though there was no mirth in it. “Dream or not, there are few left in these parts who remember the first songs of the earth. If he walks still, he will know why the wild has grown restless.”

The path dipped, and ahead the hedge broke open, revealing the first true sight of the Old Forest: deep, tangled boughs stretching endlessly eastward, the trees leaning inward as though whispering one to another. The air itself felt thicker, cooler, and strange.

Marlo stopped at the edge and touched the hilt of his dagger. “Looks welcoming, doesn’t it?” he muttered. “Almost as if it’s waiting for us.”

Elric’s eyes narrowed as he stepped forward into the shade. “Then let us not keep it waiting.”

And together, they crossed beneath the boughs where light and silence tangled, carrying with them the uneasy knowledge that Middle-earth was no longer as it had been.

“It should not be here,” Marlo muttered at last, breaking the silence. His voice was rough, as though he had been arguing with himself for miles. “A warg, Elric. In these parts. In the Old Forest, no less.” He shook his head, tugging his cloak tighter around his shoulders. “Something’s not right. Wargs roam the wild hills of the north and east, aye, but not here — never this close to Bree.”

They fell silent again, and the hush of the Old Forest deepened around them, broken only by the crunch of their boots on the damp path. The air seemed thicker here, heavy with damp earth and resin, and the branches arched like ribs above them, blotting out more of the sky with every step.

Elric’s hand brushed the hilt of the short sword at his side. “Did you hear it?” he whispered suddenly.

Marlo stiffened. “Hear what?”

“That sound... like something moving.”

The forest gave no answer but for the sighing of the leaves. Yet both men stood still, listening, their breaths held tight. Then, faint and distant, there came a creak — as though some heavy bough had shifted — followed by the soft patter of something retreating deeper into the trees.

Marlo’s jaw tightened, and his hand went to the haft of his walking stave. “If the forest wants us gone, it’ll have to try harder than that,” he muttered, though his voice lacked its usual bravado.

But Elric’s gaze lingered on the shadows ahead, his expression taut. “It feels... aware,” he said softly. “Not angry. Just... watching.”

A crow cawed somewhere above them, harsh and sudden, and the sound carried strange echoes beneath the canopy. Marlo flinched despite himself and then let out a sharp breath.

“I’ll say this much, Elric — if Radagast can’t make sense of what’s happening, and Gandalf’s not to be found, then this Tom Bombadil of yours best be real, or we’ll have walked into a trap with no way out.”

Elric nodded, though he said nothing.

The light beneath the canopy deepened as they pressed farther into the Old Forest, where ancient trunks rose like pillars of some forgotten hall and the air hung heavy with damp earth and old secrets. Moss clung thick to gnarled roots, and the paths wound in strange, unsettling patterns as though the land itself sought to mislead them.

Elric walked at the front, boots muffled on the loam, his cloak drawn close against the cool shadows. He carried his sword now, unsheathed, its faint steel glimmering dimly beneath the mottled sunlight. Behind him, Marlo trod more heavily, his travelling cloak brushing ferns and low branches, his hand resting on the hilt of his short blade.

“We should be prepared for any eventuality,” Elric said at last, his voice low but firm, as though wary of being overheard. “There have been rumours about this forest since the days of my grandsire—but rumours are one thing. Dead hobbits are another.”

The wind moved faintly through the leaves overhead, and for a moment the forest seemed to whisper in tongues they could not understand. Marlo turned in place, eyes wide, as though expecting to see faces among the gnarled bark.

“It feels wrong,” he said. “Like the trees themselves know what we carry. Like they’re watchin’ us.”

Elric didn’t answer at first. His grip tightened on the hilt of his sword, and he glanced back at the winding trail where dappled light faded into a dense, damp green. “Perhaps they are,” he murmured at last. “Old songs say these woods were once under different powers, before even the kingdoms of Men rose here. If evil is stirring, the Old Forest would know before Bree, before even the Shire.”

They walked on, deeper into the green twilight. Branches arched low overhead, twisting like the ribs of some vast beast. Somewhere far off, a crow called once, sharp and harsh, before silence closed again.

Marlo broke it at last. “If the wargs are back, Elric, what else might be walkin’ the wilds again? Orcs? Trolls?”

Elric glanced sidelong at him, his face pale beneath the hood. “Or worse.”

The whispers rose again, faint but insistent—like a language just beyond comprehension. And though the path before them seemed unchanged, each step carried them into older and deeper shadows, where the air grew colder and the weight of the ages pressed down.

Finally, Elric stopped, laying a hand on the bark of an ancient oak as he turned to Marlo. “Whatever we find in this forest,” he said gravely, “it is no longer the world we knew, my friend. This is no time for half-measures. Keep your wits about you... and your blade ready.”

Marlo nodded, swallowing hard, his earlier determination giving way to something heavier—a creeping sense of dread. “Aye. Ready I’ll be.”

The forest seemed to breathe around them, alive and watchful. Somewhere behind the layers of moss and bark, the memory of older powers stirred, and in the deepening hush, it felt as though Middle-earth itself was holding its breath.